
Pine Lake

Waukesha County, Wisconsin — 711 acres, 85 ft, very clear

Every sheet in the Lake Country guide, bound in one document: the lake and its depth map, a page for each species, a page for each rig, and the reference sheets. Each page is also published on its own, and the two are the same document — this is those sheets bound, not a rewriting of them.

Revised 2026-07-25. Regulations quoted anywhere in this document are the 2026–27 rules and they change every year. Only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.

What is in here

Part	Sheets
I. The lake	Pine Lake — overview, depth map with numbered spots, and the season-by-season table of what holds where
II. Species	Largemouth bass, smallmouth bass, walleye, northern pike, muskellunge, bluegill, pumpkinseed, black crappie, yellow perch, rock bass, cisco
III. Rigs	Slip bobber, lindy, Carolina, Texas, wacky, drop shot, jig-and-minnow, three-way, split shot, quick-strike, tip-up
IV. Reference	Reading water, lures and baits, the seasonal calendar, knots, handling and release, a first trip
V. Cooking	A filleting and cooking sheet for each of the eleven species, including the five-fillet method that defeats a pike's Y-bones
VI. Field workbook	Evidence questions, prediction form, measurement log, trip checkpoints, and post-trip proof

How to use it

The numbered spots on the depth map are the guide's spine. Every species sheet and most rig sheets refer back to them, so Pine 4" or North 5" always means the same piece of water. Read the lake sheet first; after that the guide is meant to be flipped through rather than read.

I The Lake

The water itself: what it is made of, how deep it goes, where the structure is, and which of the nine (or seven) marked spots is worth your time in which month.

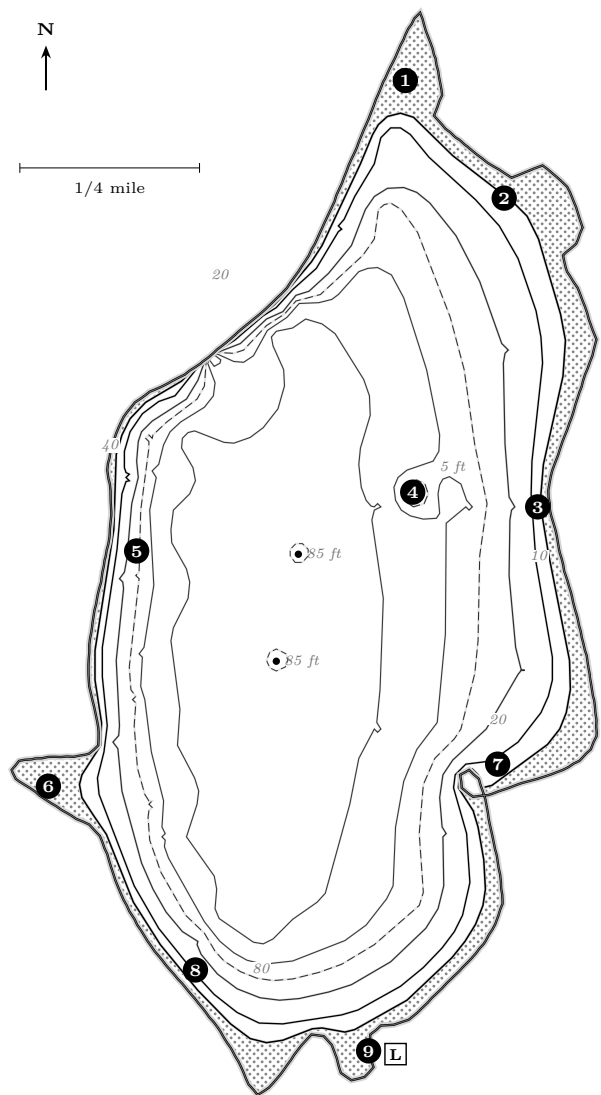
Pine Lake

Town of Merton & Village of Chenequa

Waukesha County, Wisconsin — 711 acres, 85 ft maximum depth

Pine Lake is deep, cold and startlingly clear, and almost everything that makes it hard to fish follows from those three facts. Ninety per cent of the bottom is gravel. The water clears far enough that weeds grow past 15 ft, that fish see your line, and that the best bites come at the edges of the day. It stratifies hard by early summer into a warm upper layer and a cold, oxygenated basin below, and it holds cisco — an open-water forage fish — which means the biggest predators in this lake spend much of the summer suspended over 60 ft of water rather than sitting on the weed edge where you would like them to be.

Surface	711 acres (698 acres on the 1955 survey); 6.7 miles of shoreline
Depth	85 ft maximum, 39 ft mean — one of the deepest lakes in the county
Bottom	Gravel 90%, muck 5%, sand 5%. Hard bottom nearly everywhere
Clarity	Very clear. Expect weed growth to 15–20 ft and spooky fish in calm sun
Fish	Largemouth and smallmouth bass (common), panfish, northern pike, walleye (stocked as large fingerlings in alternate years), cisco
Access	One public launch, Village of Chenequa. 6 a.m.–10 p.m., except the general fishing opener when it opens 4 a.m.–midnight. Launch fees apply (roughly \$8–\$15 by boat length); verify current hours and fees



Depth in feet. Schematic — not for navigation. Redrawn from the Wisconsin Conservation Department lake survey of 6 June 1955 (WBIC 779200), published by the Wisconsin DNR as a public document. Contours are reconstructed from that survey's soundings and are generalized.

under 5 ft shoreline 5 & 10 ft 20 ft 30 ft 40 & 60 ft 80 ft 4 spot L public launch

The nine spots, by season

Depths below are where the fish are, not where the spot is. Everything on this lake runs deeper than you expect because the water is so clear.

#	Spot	When & what	How
1	North arm shallows	Apr–early Jun: bluegill, pumpkinseed, largemouth, early pike. Nov–Mar: panfish under ice.	First water in the lake to warm. Fish 3–8 ft over emerging weed. Slip bobber and a small leech or half a crawler; a weightless wacky-rigged worm for bass.
2	North-east shoreline break	May–Jun smallmouth; Sep–Nov walleye and pike.	A scalloped shore with points and pockets and a fast drop. Work the points with a jig-and-minnow along the 12–20 ft line; cast tubes to the rock in spring.
3	East wall	Jul–Sep smallmouth, walleye, suspended fish.	The steepest drop in the lake — 20 ft is a short cast from shore. Drop-shot or a slow lindy rig down the 25–40 ft face. Best at first and last light.
4	Mid-lake bar	Jun–Oct , the whole cast: smallmouth, walleye, crappie, big pike.	A hard 5 ft crest surrounded by 60 ft. The single best piece of structure here. Start on top at dawn, then follow the fish down the sides to 18–30 ft as the sun climbs. Jig-and-minnow, drop-shot, or a deep crankbait on the edge.
5	West shelf	May–Sep largemouth and bluegill; Oct pike.	The gentlest slope in the lake, with the deepest weed growth. Fish the outside weed edge at 12–18 ft. Texas-rigged plastic through the weeds, slip bobber on the edge.
6	West bay	Late May–Jun bluegill and pumpkinseed on beds; largemouth all summer. Jan–Feb panfish.	Shallow, protected and weedy — the classic spawning bay. Small hook, small bait, light line, and stay back from the beds. Prime water to put a child on fish.
7	South-east bay	Apr–May crappie and bluegill; Jun–Aug largemouth.	A small round pocket that warms early and holds spring fish before the main lake turns on. Slip bobber over 6–12 ft.
8	South-west taper	Sep–Nov walleye and pike; Jun–Aug smallmouth deep.	Deep water swings close to the bank here. Troll or drift the 20–35 ft break with a lindy rig and a big minnow in fall.
9	Outlet bay	Apr–May and Oct–Nov pike; panfish in summer.	Shallow, weedy, with some current. Pike stage here early and again in fall. Big sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, or a spinnerbait over the weed tops.

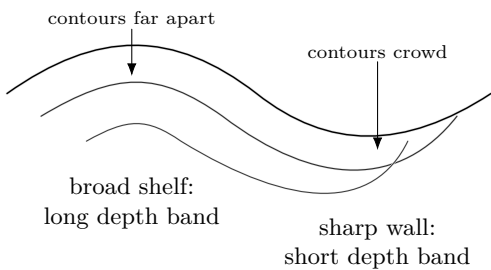
Build a three-stop route

Start at spot _____ to test _____; move to spot _____ only if _____; finish at spot _____ to compare _____. Keep _____ unchanged across all three stops.

Reading the year

Ice-out–April	Everything is shallow and everything is in the bays. Spots 1, 6, 7, 9. Water under 50 °F: slow down, use bait.
May–June	Spawn moves through in order — pike first, then walleye, then bass, then panfish last on the beds. Fish stay shallow. Bass season opens the first Saturday in May; check the current dates.
July–August	The lake stratifies. Panfish and largemouth hold the deep weed edge (spots 5, 6); smallmouth, walleye and big pike go to the bar and the east wall (3, 4) or suspend over the basin chasing cisco.
September–October	Turnover scatters fish for a week or two, then the best fishing of the year begins. Big fish move up onto structure and eat hard. Spots 2, 4, 8.
November–ice	Deep and slow. The bar and the east wall hold fish into December.
Ice season	Panfish in the bays (1, 6); pike on tip-ups over the weed edges. <i>Walleye, bass and pike close 7 March; panfish stay open.</i>

Learn to see the break



The map gives you shapes, not today’s fish. Work these questions in pencil before the boat goes in:

- 1. At spots 2, 5 and 8, draw a cast that begins shallow and crosses the 20-ft contour. Which cast samples the widest band of bottom?
- 2. Put the boat on the deep side of spot 3. How far can wind move you before a vertical presentation is no longer on the wall?
- 3. Trace two routes from the top of spot 4 to 40 ft. Circle the one exposed to today’s wind. That is a hypothesis about activity, not an answer.
- 4. Mark one shallow bay, one weed edge, one hard break and one open-water scan. What observation will make you abandon each?

Write the prediction first
I expect fish at _____ ft near spot _____ because _____. I will give that idea _____ minutes or _____ clean passes. Evidence that defeats it: _____.

What only today’s lake can tell you

Claim	Field test
The weed edge is 15–20 ft	Cross it on two headings and record where continuous living growth actually stops.
The gravel break holds fish	Require repeatable sonar marks, bait, contact or bites at a recorded depth; hard bottom alone is not a pattern.
Predators are chasing cisco offshore	Scan two basin routes and match marks on reciprocal passes. One arch is not a school.

Make three measurements the same way

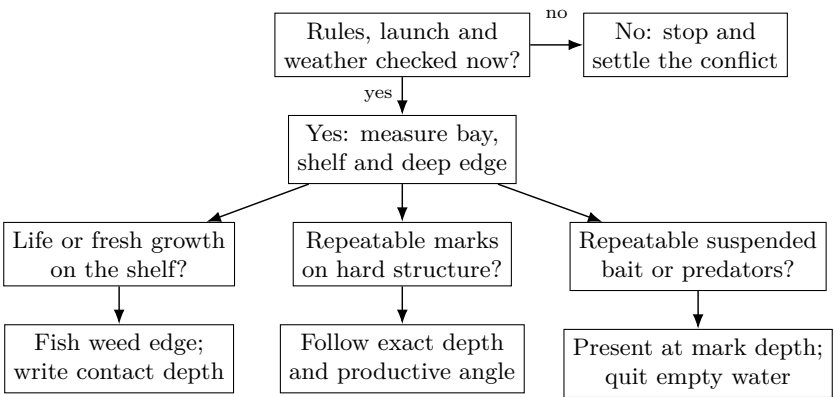
1. **Fix the stations.** Pick a protected bay, the west shelf and a basin-side structure. Note the map number or lawful waypoint. Return to these same stations rather than choosing prettier water each trip.
2. **Depth.** Outside traffic, let sonar settle and record depth on opposite headings. A marked sounding line is a useful check only with propulsion stopped, PFD worn, and line kept away from feet and propeller.
3. **Temperature.** Shade the thermometer. Wait for a stable surface reading, then repeat at 5, 10 and 20 ft where possible. Use equal wait times. Write “not measured” when wind or depth prevents a safe reading.
4. **Clarity.** On the shaded side, lower a black-and-white Secchi disk until it disappears. Raise it to reappearance. Average the depths; repeat once. Stay seated or braced and stop if waves make leaning unsafe.
5. **Describe the test.** Record wind, sky, recent rain, traffic, surface debris, vegetation height and whether the reading was stable.

Do not manufacture a thermocline
Four temperatures can show a useful change, but not a complete profile. They do not prove dissolved oxygen. Use a calibrated oxygen meter if oxygen matters; otherwise leave it unknown.

Questions after the third station

1. Where did the two depth headings disagree most? _____. Was the cause likely slope, weeds, waves, speed or instrument setup?
2. The clearest station was _____; its Secchi mean was _____ ft. Did fish or bait sit shallower or deeper there?
3. Which observation contradicted the written seasonal pattern? _____. What is the cheapest next test?

Let evidence choose the next move



THE LAKE GETS THE LAST WORD

Recheck at the launch. If the posted rule differs from a saved note, follow the current authoritative direction. If observed wind, lightning, visibility or waves exceed the crew or craft, do not launch or come back immediately.

CHECK THE REGULATIONS BEFORE EVERY TRIP

The 2026–27 rules for this water are: largemouth and smallmouth bass 14in minimum, 5 per day, 2 May–7 March, catch-and-release the rest of the year; walleye 18in minimum, 3 per day; northern pike 26in minimum, 2 per day; muskellunge 40in minimum, 1 per day, open water only through 31 December; panfish 25 per day; cisco and whitefish 10 per day. **These change.** The Wisconsin DNR publishes the current rules for this exact water body, and only that publication is authoritative.

Close the loop at home

One trip, one revised belief
The strongest repeated evidence was _____. It supports / weakens my prediction because _____. On the next trip I will hold _____ constant and change only _____.

1. Transfer useful waypoints with date, water level context and confidence; delete accidental marks and never rename a guess as a hazard.
2. Compare all three stations before calling a lake-wide pattern.
3. Note the first observation that changed your plan and whether changing early saved time.
4. Clean, drain and remove plants and animals before moving equipment.
5. Recheck this workbook’s seasonal claims after three comparable trips.

Field worksheets

Departure gate

Verify today	Evidence, source, time	Go?
Exact-water regulation and season		Yes / No
Launch sign, hours, fee and ordinance		Yes / No
Forecast, radar, wind direction and gusts		Yes / No
Lightning, fog, waves or high-water notice		Yes / No
PFDs, lights, communication and re- turn route		Yes / No

Pine water log

Date/time	Station	Depth ft	Temp: face/5/10/20 ft	sur- Secchi: down/up/mean ft	Wind, growth, bait, confidence

Evidence notebook

Time / spot	Claim tested	Evidence for and against	Next move and reason

Next-trip control sheet

Hold constant	Tool / station / depth / presentation / time window
Measurement method	
Comparison station	
Change one thing	New test and the result that would reject it

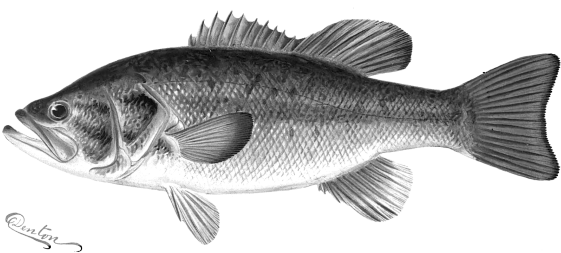
Fishing variable

Map claim

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II Species

One page each. How to tell it apart from the fish it gets confused with, where it lives in this lake, when it spawns, and how to catch it. The plates are public-domain chromolithographs by S. F. Denton, published in the New York fisheries reports around 1896–1902.



The Large-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

The jaw. On a largemouth the upper jaw reaches *past* the back of the eye; on a smallmouth it stops under the eye. Largemouth are green with one ragged dark stripe down the side, and the dorsal fin is pinched almost in two.

Size here

12–16 in is a normal fish, 18 in is a good one, 20 in is a trophy for these lakes. State record 11 lb 3 oz.

Spawn

Beds in 1–4 ft of sand or gravel in protected bays when the water holds 60–65 °F — late May into June. The male fans the bed and guards the fry for weeks afterward.

Eats

Anything it can fit: bluegill, perch, crayfish, frogs, young of its own kind.

Season

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Dawn		Mid		Dusk		Night					

Time of day

Where

- Pine

Spots **5** (west shelf), **6** (west bay), **7** (south-east bay). The water is so clear that the weed line runs to 15–20 ft, and so does the bass. Do not stop fishing at 8 ft because that is where you would stop on a normal lake.
- North

Spots **1**, **4**, **5**, **7**. Stained water pulls them shallow — 4–10 ft is the band.
- Structure

Weed edges, isolated weed clumps, fallen wood, docks, and any hard-to-soft bottom transition. A largemouth wants something to hide behind and open water to charge into.

How

- In the weeds

Texas-rigged plastic worm or creature bait, *see the **Texas rig** sheet*. Weedless, sinks slowly, comes through everything.
- Pressured or clear

Weightless wacky-rigged worm, *see the **wacky rig** sheet*. On Pine Lake in bright sun this out-fishes everything else.
- Deep

A jig-and-craw or a Carolina rig on the outside weed edge, *see the **Carolina rig** sheet*.
- First and last light

A walking topwater or a popper over the weed tops. The best half hour of the day.
- For a beginner

A nightcrawler under a slip bobber set to hang just above the weeds. It is not fancy and it works.

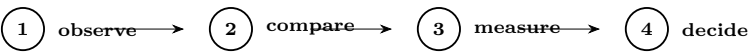
The one thing to remember

Largemouth relate to *cover*, not depth. Find the edge — of the weeds, of the shade, of the drop — and fish it. In the middle of a featureless flat there is no bass.

Worth knowing

How old is it?	In water this cold, a largemouth reaches about 12 in in four years, 15 in in six, and 18 in in eight to ten. The 20 in fish you are hoping for is older than the boy holding the rod.
It lives in a small world	Tagging studies consistently show largemouth holding home ranges of only a few acres, often returning to the same log or dock edge for years. A good spot is good repeatedly — which is why the numbered spots on the lake sheets are worth learning.
It hears with its body	The lateral line detects pressure waves at a few metres — a bass finds a lure in muddy water or full dark by feel. This is why a thumping spinnerbait blade works at night and a silent finesse worm does not.
It eats by suction	That bucket mouth opens fast and the fish inhales a volume of water. It is why a slack-line take feels like nothing, and why fixed-position baits like a wacky worm get eaten so confidently.
Cold shuts it down	Below about 50 °F a largemouth’s metabolism drops so far it may feed once every several days. That is not a fish being fussy — it genuinely does not need your lure.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	With the mouth closed, does the rear of the upper jaw extend beyond the eye?
Rule out	Smallmouth jaw ends under the eye and its dorsal fin is not deeply pinched; ignore colour alone.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: press the snout to the board stop and read the longest tail tip without stretching.
Field proof	Jaw reach and dorsal shape must agree before counting it as largemouth. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

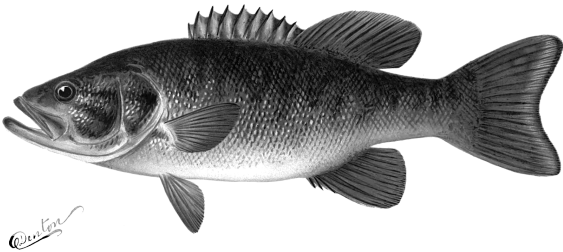
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 14 in minimum, 5 per day, open 2 May–7 March. Catch-and-release open all year. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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Smallmouth Bass

Rock, gravel and hard bottom — Pine Lake & North Lake

Micropterus dolomieu



The Small-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	Bronze rather than green, with dark <i>vertical</i> bars instead of one horizontal stripe, and a red or orange eye. The upper jaw stops under the eye. The dorsal fin is one continuous fin, not pinched.																																																																	
Size here	12–17 in typical; 18 in and up is a strong fish. State record 9 lb 1 oz. Pound for pound the hardest-fighting fish in either lake.																																																																	
Spawn	Gravel and rubble in 3–10 ft at 60–65 °F, a little later and deeper than largemouth. Pine Lake’s 90% gravel bottom is close to ideal smallmouth habitat.																																																																	
Eats	Crayfish above all, then minnows, perch fry and insect larvae. Match the crayfish and you are most of the way there.																																																																	
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Where

Pine	This is a smallmouth lake. Spots 2 (north-east breaks), 3 (east wall), 4 (the mid-lake bar) and 8 . The bar is the best smallmouth spot in the county on a good October morning.
North	Spots 3 and 4 . The south-end shoal complex is the equivalent of Pine’s bar.
Structure	Hard bottom with a fast change in depth. Rock points, gravel bars, rip-rap, boulder fields. If your jig comes back scuffed, you are in the right place.
Season	Shallow and aggressive in May–June, deep and moody in July–August, then shallow and violent again in late September and October.

How

Best all-round	A tube jig dragged and hopped on the bottom. It looks exactly like a fleeing crayfish and nothing else is needed most days.
Deep and finicky	Drop-shot with a small minnow-shaped plastic, <i>see the drop-shot sheet</i> . This is how you fish Pine Lake’s east wall in August.
Cold water	A suspending jerkbait, worked with long pauses. In 45–55 °F water the pause is the whole presentation.
Live bait	A live crayfish or a large leech on a plain hook with one split shot, <i>see the split shot sheet</i> . Deadly and simple.

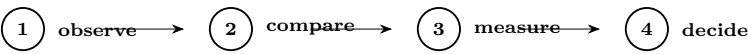
The one thing to remember

Smallmouth live where the bottom is hard. Largemouth live where the cover is soft. On the same lake, on the same day, that one distinction sorts almost every spot.

Worth knowing

Slower than you think	Smallmouth grow more slowly than largemouth in the same water. A 17 in smallmouth in southern Wisconsin is commonly eight to ten years old. There are not many of them and they do not replace quickly.
They hunt in groups	Unlike largemouth, smallmouth commonly patrol in loose packs of similar-sized fish. If you catch one on a bar, cast straight back — the school is usually still there, and the competition makes them bolder.
Crayfish, overwhelmingly	Stomach studies on rocky lakes routinely find crayfish as the dominant food by volume. Everything about a tube jig — the profile, the bottom contact, the puff of sediment — is an imitation of one fleeing backwards.
They fight above their weight	A smallmouth’s caudal peduncle — the muscle in front of the tail — is proportionally larger than a largemouth’s, and its habit of running to open water rather than into cover is why a two-pounder feels like four.
The nest is guarded hard	A male smallmouth will strike a lure dropped on his bed out of aggression, not hunger, and he will keep doing it. It is easy fishing and it costs the year class. Move off beds you can see.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	With the mouth closed, does the upper jaw stop beneath the eye, with a nearly continuous dorsal fin?
Rule out	Largemouth jaw extends beyond the eye and the dorsal is deeply pinched; body colour changes with water.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: press the closed snout to the board stop and read the longest tail tip.
Field proof	Jaw reach and dorsal shape must agree before counting it as smallmouth. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

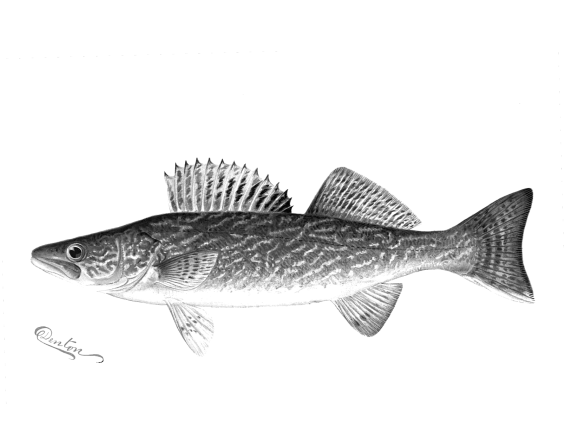
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Walleye

Sander vitreus

The low-light specialist — Pine Lake & North Lake



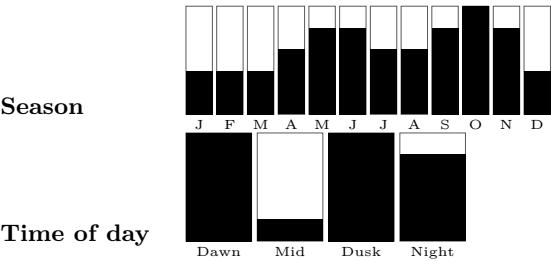
The Pike Perch or Wall-Eyed Pike — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart A **white tip on the lower lobe of the tail** and a dark blotch at the rear base of the spiny dorsal fin. The eye is large and glassy — a reflective layer behind the retina lets it see in water too dark for its prey. Long canine teeth.

Not a sauger Sauger have rows of black spots on the spiny dorsal, dark saddles, and no white tail tip. Not expected here, but worth knowing.

Size here 15–22 in. The 18 in minimum means most fish you catch go back. State record 18 lb.

Spawn Earliest of the gamefish after pike: 42–50 °F, late March into April, over rock and gravel shorelines and in inflows. Pine Lake is stocked with large fingerlings in alternate years.



Where

Pine Spots **3** (east wall), **4** (the bar) and **8**. In high summer they may suspend over the basin following cisco — do not assume they are on the bottom.

North Spots **3**, **4** (south-end shoals) and **5** (the neck). Stained water means they will be shallower than on Pine.

Depth The 18–30 ft break most of the year. Shallower at dawn, dusk and after dark; deeper in bright calm.

Weather Grey and windy is a walleye day. Wind on a point breaks up the light and pushes bait against structure — fish the windy side.

How

Classic Lindy rig with a leech, half a crawler, or a small minnow, dragged slowly along the contour, *see the lindy rig sheet*. Slow means slower than you think.

Cold water Jig-and-minnow, *see the jig-and-minnow sheet*, worked with tiny lifts. Most bites feel like weight, not a strike.

Steep faces A three-way rig holds a precise depth where a lindy rig will not, *see the three-way rig sheet*.

Timing The last forty minutes of light beat the rest of the day. Be on the spot before the sun goes.

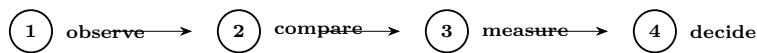
The one thing to remember

Walleye are not hard to catch; they are hard to be present for. Their eyes give them an advantage in dim light, so they feed when you would rather be at the landing. Fish the edges of the day.

Worth knowing

The eye is the whole fish	The <i>tapetum lucidum</i> is a reflective layer behind the retina that bounces light back through it a second time. It gives a walleye roughly a full order of magnitude of light advantage over the perch it hunts — and it is why the fish avoids bright sun, not because it dislikes it but because in daylight the advantage disappears.
So fish the light, not the clock	Dawn, dusk, night, a chop on the water, a cloudy front, stained water: all the same thing to a walleye. On Pine Lake's very clear water the effect is exaggerated, which is why the bite window there is narrow and worth being present for.
Growth	Females grow considerably faster and larger than males. Nearly every walleye over 24 in is a female. In this part of the state an 18 in fish is roughly four to six years old.
Stocked, not self-sustaining	Pine Lake receives large fingerling walleye in alternate years. That is a strong hint that natural reproduction is limited here — the population is a managed one, and the size structure reflects stocking years.
They travel at night	Radio-tracking on similar lakes shows walleye moving substantial distances after dark, up onto flats they never visit in daylight. The fish that was not on your break at noon may be in 8 ft of water at eleven at night.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Is the white tip confined to the lower tail lobe, with a dark blotch at the rear of the first dorsal?
Rule out	Sauger lack the white tip and carry rows of spots across the spiny dorsal; do not decide from the glassy eye.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: close the toothed mouth against the stop and keep fingers clear of gill plates.
Field proof	White tail tip and dorsal blotch must both be visible. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

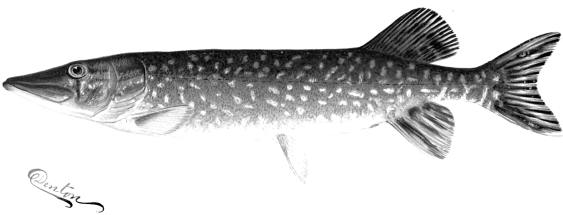
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 18 in minimum, 3 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Walleye. Revised 20260725.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

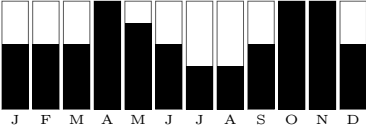
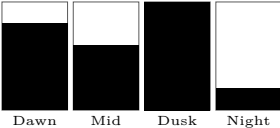
Northern Pike

Esox lucius

First to spawn, last to quit — Pine Lake & North Lake



The Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	Light bean-shaped spots on a dark green body — light-on-dark. The cheek is fully scaled and the lower half of the gill cover is bare. Five sensory pores along each side of the lower jaw.
Not a musky	A musky is the photographic negative: <i>dark</i> marks on a <i>light</i> body, the lower half of both the cheek and gill cover bare, and six to nine pores per side. At a 40 in minimum on musky and 26 in on pike, this matters.
Size here	20–30 in is the working range; 36 in and up is a real fish. State record 38 lb.
Spawn	The first gamefish to go, immediately after ice-out at 40–45 °F, in flooded marsh grass and shallow vegetation — often before the ice is fully gone from the main lake.
Season	
Time of day	

Where

Pine	Spots 1 and 9 in spring and fall, 5 along the deep weed edge in summer. In a lake this cold and clear, the largest pike go deep and cool in July and August — 25–40 ft on the edge of the basin, not in the shallows.
North	Spots 2 (outlet), 5 (the neck) and 6 (river inlet). Current and weed. This lake fishes more like a classic pike water than Pine does.
Cover	Weed edges, points, and any narrows. Pike are ambush hunters that want a wall at their back and open water in front.

How

Big fish	A large sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, <i>see the quick-strike rig sheet</i> . This is how most of the biggest pike in these lakes are taken.
Ice	Tip-ups with a live shiner set just off the bottom along the weed edge, <i>see the tip-up sheet</i> .
Leader	Always. A wire or heavy fluorocarbon leader. Pike teeth cut straight line, and losing a fish with a hook in it is a bad outcome for the fish, not just for you.

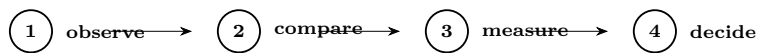
HANDLING A PIKE

The teeth are backward-facing and will cut you to the bone. Long pliers and jaw spreaders, always; fingers never go in the mouth or under the gill plate. Support a big fish horizontally with a wet hand under the belly. Above roughly 70 °F a released pike is fragile — unhook it in the net, in the water, and let it go.

Worth knowing

Built for one strike	A pike accelerates from rest at close to eight body lengths per second, using a body shape — fins bunched at the back, like the flights on a dart — optimised entirely for a single explosive lunge. It is a poor endurance swimmer, which is why it ambushes and does not chase far.
They eat things far too big	Pike routinely take prey a third to half their own length, including other pike. A 30 in fish will attack a 12 in one. This is why a bait most people think is absurdly large is often exactly right.
The big ones are all female	Female pike grow faster, live longer and reach far greater size. Every pike over about 34 in in these lakes is almost certainly a female, and killing them removes the fish producing the next generation.
Heat is their limit	Pike are a cool-water fish and become stressed above roughly 75 °F. In a clear deep lake like Pine they simply leave — the big ones go down to 25–40 ft in July, which is why the shallow weed edge produces only small ones in summer.
Spawn before the ice is gone	Pike move into flooded marsh grass at 40–45 °F, sometimes with ice still on the main lake. They are done spawning before a bass has thought about it.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Are the spots light on dark, the tail lobes rounded, and five jaw pores present per side?
Rule out	Musky show dark marks on light ground, pointed tail lobes, and six to nine pores; pattern alone is insufficient.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: wet the board, close the mouth, support the belly, and read before prolonged air exposure.
Field proof	Pattern, pores, and tail shape must all agree before harvest. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

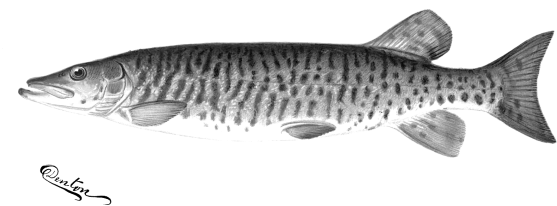
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 26 in minimum, 2 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Northern Pike. Revised 20260725.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Muskellunge

Esox masquinongy

An incidental fish here — but know it on sight



The Mascalonge — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Pattern	Dark bars or spots on a <i>light</i> body — the exact reverse of a northern pike.
Cheek	Lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless.
Jaw pores	Six to nine per side. A pike has five or fewer.
Tail	Lobes come to sharper points than a pike's.
Minimum	40 in, 1 per day, open water only.

Why this sheet exists
Muskellunge are not among the species the DNR lists as common in Pine Lake or North Lake. They are nonetheless regulated on both waters, at a 40 in minimum and one fish per day. If you hook a large esocid here it is almost certainly a northern pike — but you must be able to prove that to yourself before you decide what to do with it, because the two fish carry different minimum lengths and different seasons.

Musky or pike? Three checks, in order

1. Pattern	Musky: dark bars or spots on a light background. Pike: light bean-shaped spots on a dark background. The two are photographic negatives of one another.
2. Cheek & gill cover	Look at the side of the head. Musky: the lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless. Pike: the whole cheek is scaled; only the lower gill cover is bare.
3. Jaw pores	Turn the head and count the pores along one side of the underside of the lower jaw. Musky: six to nine. Pike: five or fewer. This is the check that settles an argument.
Tail	A musky's tail lobes come to sharper points; a pike's are more rounded. Useful as confirmation, not as the deciding test.
Tiger musky	A pike-musky hybrid, with bold wavy bars and rounded tail lobes. It falls under the musky regulations.

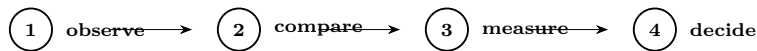
If you do hook one

Decide fast	Measure it in the net, in the water. Under 40 in it goes back, full stop.
Gear	A big musky cannot be landed responsibly on panfish tackle. A large net, long pliers, jaw spreaders and bolt cutters for a buried hook are the minimum.
Release	Keep it horizontal and in the water. A musky is a long, heavy fish and its own weight in air injures it. Revive it facing into the current or move it gently forward until it swims off under its own power.
Season	Open water only, 2 May–31 December — unlike pike, there is no ice season for musky.

Worth knowing

Slow, old and few	Muskellunge grow slowly and live fifteen to twenty years or more. A 40 in fish is well into double-digit age. There is no such thing as a common musky.
Top of the chain, top of the mercury	Long life plus a diet of other predators is exactly the recipe for accumulating mercury, which is why Wisconsin's health guidance puts musky in a category of its own. <i>see the Cooking Muskellunge sheet</i>
They follow without eating	A musky commonly tracks a lure to the boat and turns away. This is normal behaviour, not a missed opportunity, and it is why musky anglers finish every cast with a figure-eight at the boat.
The pore count is the legal test	Six to nine pores per side of the lower jaw on a musky, five or fewer on a pike. At a 40 in minimum against 26 in, being able to do that check in ten seconds is a legal matter, not a trivia question.
The tail lobes	Pointed on a musky, rounded on a pike. A useful confirmation once the pattern and the pores agree.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Are the marks dark on a light body, the tail lobes pointed, and six to nine jaw pores present per side?
Rule out	Pike show light bean-shaped spots on a dark body, rounder tail lobes, and five pores per side.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: measure in the water on a floating board whenever possible; never suspend the fish by its jaw.
Field proof	Pattern, pore count, and tail shape must all agree; one ambiguous mark means release. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

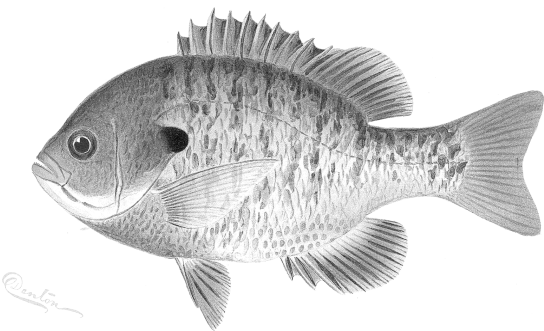
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 40 in minimum, 1 per day, open water only, 2 May–31 December. A misidentified fish is still a violation. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Muskellunge. Revised 20260725.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus

The best fish in the lake to learn on



Blue Gill Sun Fish — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

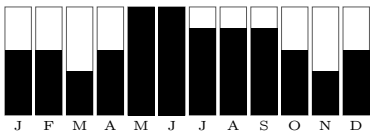
Tell it apart A solid black ear flap with no coloured margin, a dark smudge at the rear base of the soft dorsal fin, a small mouth, and long pointed pectoral fins. Compare with the pumpkinseed, which has an orange-red spot on the flap and wavy blue lines on the cheek.

Size here 6–8 in is a good fish; a 9 in bluegill is a genuine trophy and worth releasing so it keeps breeding.

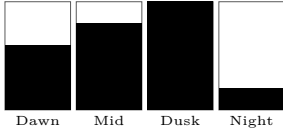
Spawn 67–70 °F, late May into June, in dense colonies of saucer-shaped beds on sand or gravel in 1–4 ft. You can see the beds from the boat and often smell them.

Eats Insect larvae, small crustaceans, snails. A small mouth means small baits.

Season



Time of day



Where

- Pine** Spots **6** (west bay) and **1** on the beds in June, then out to the deep weed edge at **5** — 12–18 ft — for the rest of the summer. Bluegill on Pine go deeper than most people expect.
- North** Spots **1** and **7**, and the weed flats generally. 4–10 ft.
- Winter** Basin edges and remaining green weed at 10–20 ft. Bays **6** on Pine, **1** on North.

How

- The rig** A slip bobber, a small split shot, and a size 8 or 10 hook, *see the slip bobber sheet*. Set the depth so the bait rides just above the weed tops.
- Bait** A piece of nightcrawler — not a whole one — a waxworm, a leaf worm, or a small leech. Bluegill have small mouths and will strip a big bait without ever getting hooked.
- Line** 4lb. Anything heavier telegraphs badly on a small float and costs you bites.
- With a child** This is the fish. Anchor over a bed in June, use a fixed bobber a foot or two deep, and expect constant action. Barbless or pinched barbs make unhooking fast and safe.

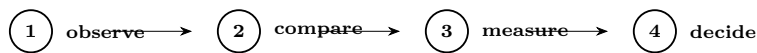
Fish the beds gently

Bedding bluegill are easy to catch and easy to strip out of a bay. Take a meal, not a cooler. The biggest males guard the beds, and removing them all is how a lake ends up full of stunted four-inch fish.

Worth knowing

There are two kinds of male	Large <i>parental</i> males build and guard the nests. Smaller <i>sneaker</i> males never build one — they mature years earlier, stay small, and dart into another male’s nest to fertilise eggs. The two strategies coexist permanently in every bluegill population.
Which is why big ones matter	Remove the large parental males from a bay and the population tilts toward small early-maturing fish. That is the mechanism behind a lake full of stunted four-inch bluegill — it is a consequence of harvest, not of overcrowding alone.
Colonial nesting	Beds are built in dense colonies, sometimes hundreds of saucers touching edge to edge in a few feet of water. You can see them from the boat, and on a calm June evening you can smell them.
Age	A 7 in bluegill in these lakes is commonly five to seven years old. A 9 in one may be ten. They are far older than their size suggests.
The pectoral fin is a giveaway	Long and pointed on a bluegill, short and rounded on a pumpkinseed. Useful when the ear flap is ambiguous on a hybrid.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Is the ear flap solid black, the mouth small, and the pectoral fin long and pointed?
Rule out	Pumpkinseed show an orange-red flap margin; hybrids may mix marks, so do not decide from body colour.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: flatten the tail naturally and measure to its longest point.
Field proof	Ear flap, mouth, and pectoral shape should all agree. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

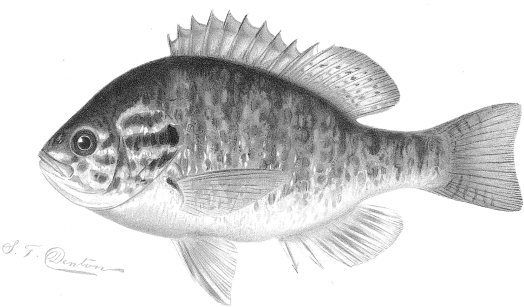
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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Pumpkinseed

The other sunfish on the bed

Lepomis gibbosus



Sunfish (*Eupomotis gibbosus*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	An orange-red spot on the trailing edge of the black ear flap, and wavy pale-blue lines radiating back across the cheek and gill cover. The fins are speckled. There is <i>no</i> dark blotch at the back of the soft dorsal — that blotch belongs to the bluegill.																								
Shape	Rounder and deeper-bodied than a bluegill, with a slightly larger mouth and shorter, more rounded pectoral fins.																								
Size here	5–7 in. Rarely as large as a good bluegill, and usually a smaller share of the catch.																								
Spawn	Same window as bluegill, 65–70 °F, often on the same colonial beds — and the two species hybridize, which is why you will occasionally land something that fits neither description.																								
Eats	Snails above all — it has crushing teeth in its throat for them — plus insect larvae and small crustaceans.																								
Season	<table><tr><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td></tr><tr><td>J</td><td>F</td><td>M</td><td>A</td><td>M</td><td>J</td><td>J</td><td>A</td><td>S</td><td>O</td><td>N</td><td>D</td></tr></table>													J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
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Where and how

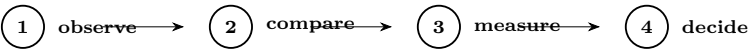
Habitat	Shallower and weedier than bluegill, and more tied to cover. Pine spots 6 and 1 ; North spots 1 and 7 .
Depth	1–8 ft, in and against vegetation. If you are catching bluegill on the deep weed edge and pumpkinseed on the inside edge, that is normal.
Rig	Identical to bluegill — slip bobber, split shot, size 8 or 10 hook, small piece of worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.

Worth knowing on the bed
When you find a June sunfish colony you will usually be catching both species plus the occasional hybrid. Sorting them on the spot is a good five-minute lesson for a child: flip the gill cover into the light and look for the orange dot.

Worth knowing

It eats snails	Pumpkinseed have specialised crushing teeth in the throat — pharyngeal jaws — strong enough to break snail shells. That is a food source almost nothing else in the lake can use, and it is why they can share a bay with bluegill without competing directly.
Shallower than bluegill	Because their food is on the bottom among vegetation, pumpkinseed hold tighter to cover and shallower than the bluegill they nest alongside. Catching bluegill deep and pumpkinseed shallow in the same bay is normal.
They hybridise freely	Bluegill–pumpkinseed crosses are common wherever both nest together, which is why you will regularly land a fish that fits neither description. Look at the ear flap first, then the pectoral fin.
The ear flap is a signal	That orange-red crescent is display colouring, brightest on nesting males in June. A dull fish in October may be much harder to tell from a bluegill.
Age	A 7 in pumpkinseed is commonly six to eight years old.

Prove it in hand



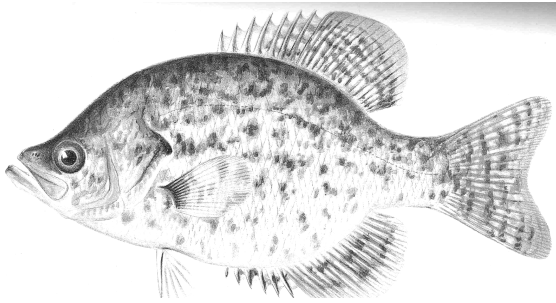
Ask first	Can you see the orange-red trailing spot on the ear flap and wavy cheek lines?
Rule out	Bluegill has a solid black flap and a dark soft-dorsal blotch; hybrids may not resolve cleanly.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: measure flat without compressing the deep body.
Field proof	Ear flap and cheek pattern should agree; label mixed fish as uncertain, not confidently pure. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

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Black Crappie

Pomoxis nigromaculatus

A roaming, suspending, low-light panfish



Calico Bass; Strawberry Bass (*Pomoxis sparoides*) — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Count the dorsal spines: seven or eight on a black crappie, five or six on a white crappie. The speckling is scattered and irregular, not organised into vertical bars. The body is deep, thin and silvery.

The paper mouth

The membrane around the jaw tears easily. Do not set hard and do not lift a crappie by the line — this is the fish people lose at the side of the boat.

Size here

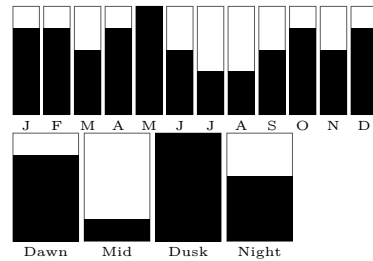
8-11 in. A 12 in crappie is a very good fish.

Spawn

58–64 °F, May, in 3–8 ft near brush, wood or the inside weed edge. Slightly earlier and slightly deeper than bluegill.

Eats

Small minnows and zooplankton. More fish-eating than the sunfish, which is why a minnow beats a worm.



Season

Time of day

Where

Pine Spot **7** (south-east bay) and **6** in spring; the edges of the mid-lake bar **4** in summer, where they suspend off the drop.

North Spots 1 and 4, and anywhere with standing wood.

The key habit Crappie **suspend**. They roam in schools at a chosen depth over deep water, ignoring the bottom entirely. Finding the depth matters far more than finding the spot.

How

Find the depth Cast a small jig, count it down — five, ten, fifteen — and retrieve. When you get bit, remember the count and repeat it exactly.

Best bait A small live minnow under a slip bobber, *see the **slip bobber sheet***, set precisely at the depth you found. Crappie feed *upward*; set the bait slightly above them, never below.

Hookset A steady sweep, not a snap. Paper mouth.

When Dusk is the crappie hour. They also feed well in the first hour of an overcast morning and through the ice in January.

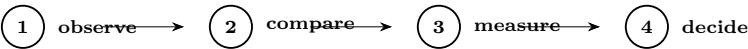
The one thing to remember

If you are catching nothing, change your *depth* before you change your bait. A school two feet below your jig will not come up for it, and a school two feet above it never sees it.

Worth knowing

They live in the middle	Crappie are among the few freshwater fish that spend most of the year genuinely pelagic — suspended in open water at a chosen depth, unrelated to the bottom. Almost every other fish in this guide relates to structure. Crappie relate to <i>depth</i> .
Boom and bust	Crappie year classes are notoriously uneven: one strong spawn can dominate a lake’s population for years, then nothing. If every crappie you catch is the same size, that is why — you are catching a single year class.
They feed upward	The eyes and the upturned mouth are built to take prey silhouetted against the surface. A bait below a crappie is invisible to it. This one fact governs how you set every slip float.
Cold water suits them	Crappie feed actively at temperatures that shut a bass down, which is why they are one of the best ice-fishing targets in either lake and why January can be as good as May.
Age	A 10 in black crappie is typically four to six years old.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Can you count seven or eight hard dorsal spines and see scattered speckles rather than bars?
Rule out	A white crappie carries five or six dorsal spines and organized vertical bars.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: record to the nearest quarter-inch; do not estimate from a hand or rod blank.
Field proof	Both spine count and pattern must agree. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

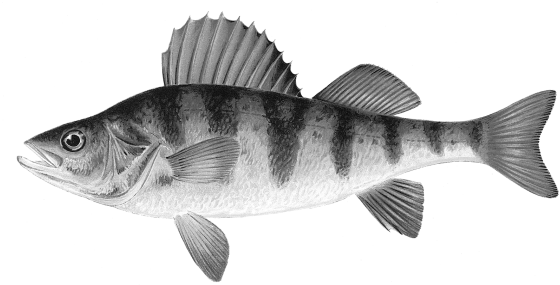
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Black Crappie. Revised 20260725.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Yellow Perch

A daylight schooling fish — and the walleye’s opposite

Perca flavescens



Yellow or Barred Perch — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

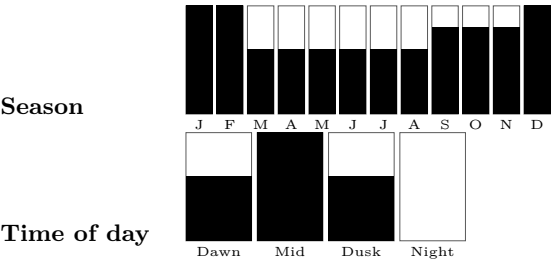
Tell it apart Six to eight dark **vertical bars** over a yellow-green body, with orange lower fins. Two separate dorsal fins, the first spiny. Unmistakable.

Size here 6–10 in. A 10 in perch is a fine fish and among the best eating in either lake.

Spawn 45–52 °F, April, and unlike any other fish here the female lays a long accordion-folded ribbon of eggs draped over weeds and brush. You will see them in the shallows.

Eats Insect larvae, small crustaceans, minnows and fish eggs. Perch are also the primary food of walleye and pike — which is exactly why they school.

Habit **A daytime feeder.** Perch shut down at night, when walleye switch on. They travel in tight schools on the bottom.



Where

Pine The deep weed edge at spot **5**, the flats around the base of the bar **4**, and the 15–30 ft bottom generally.

North Spots **1**, **3** and **4**. Shallower than on Pine because of the stain.

Bottom Perch stay on or near the bottom on clean sand, gravel or the base of weeds. If you are more than a foot off the bottom you are fishing over them.

Winter One of the best ice fish in either lake, on the same 15–30 ft flats.

How

Best rig A small jig tipped with a minnow head, a piece of crawler or a waxworm, fished right on the bottom. Or a drop-shot with a very short tag, *see the **drop-shot** sheet*.

Move to find them Perch schools are tight. If you catch two and then nothing, the school moved — move with it rather than waiting.

Stay on them When you find a school, drop straight back down immediately. A hooked fish drags the school with it and a slow re-bait costs you the whole group.

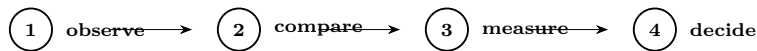
The lesson to teach

Perch and walleye eat the same food in the same water but never at the same hour: one has eyes built for daylight, the other for dusk. That single fact explains most of the daily rhythm of both lakes.

Worth knowing

Schools sort themselves by size	Perch shoal by year class, so the fish you catch in one spot tend to be the same length. If they are all too small, move — you are not going to find a big one in that school, because it is not in it.
The egg ribbon	Female perch lay a single accordion-folded gelatinous ribbon, sometimes two metres long, draped over weeds and brush. Nothing else in these lakes does this, and in April you can find them in the shallows.
Daylight only, and that is unusual	Perch have poor low-light vision and essentially stop feeding at night — the exact inverse of walleye, which hunt them. Predator and prey partition the same water by the clock.
They are the currency of the lake	Perch are the primary forage for walleye and pike here. A good perch year is followed by good walleye growth, and the size of the perch you catch tells you what the predators are eating.
Age	A 10 in perch is commonly five to seven years old and is a genuinely good fish anywhere in Wisconsin.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Are there six to eight vertical bars and two clearly separate dorsal fins, the first spiny?
Rule out	Young walleye are longer-bodied, toothed, and show the lower-tail white tip; body colour alone is unreliable.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: fold the first dorsal with a wet hand and read total length on a rigid board.
Field proof	Bars, separate dorsals, and compact perch proportions must agree. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

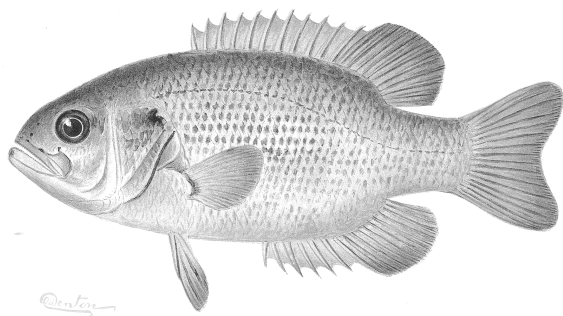
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Yellow Perch. Revised 20260725.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Rock Bass

Red-eyed, abundant, and always willing

Ambloplites rupestris



Rock Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	A bright red eye , a large mouth for a panfish, and rows of dark spots along the scale lines giving a dotted-stripe look. The clinching check: six spines in the anal fin . Bluegill, pumpkinseed and the other sunfish have three.
Colour	It can flush from pale olive to near-black in seconds, so colour alone will mislead you. Use the eye and the anal spines.
Size here	6–9 in. Abundant on Pine Lake, whose gravel bottom is exactly what they want.
Spawn	Late May into June at 60–70 °F, in shallow nests scooped on gravel near rock, often close to smallmouth beds.
Eats	Crayfish, insect larvae and small fish. Aggressive well out of proportion to its size.
Season	

Where and how

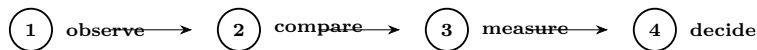
Habitat	Rock, gravel, rip-rap and boulder. Pine spots 2, 3, 4 and 8 ; North spots 3 and 4 . Wherever you fish for smallmouth you will find rock bass first.
Depth	2–20 ft, tight to the bottom and tight to cover.
Rig	They will take anything. A split-shot rig with a worm, a small jig, a tube — it hardly matters. <i>see the split shot sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.
Eating	Perfectly good — white and mild, if a little softer than perch. Under-appreciated.

Use them
Rock bass are the fish that saves a slow morning with a child, and they are the fish that tells you your smallmouth spot has the right bottom. Neither is a small thing. If you are catching rock bass on a new piece of structure, keep working it.

Worth knowing

It changes colour in seconds	Rock bass can shift from pale olive to almost black quickly, matching the bottom they are over. Colour is therefore useless for identification — use the red eye and the six anal spines.
Six spines, not three	Anal-fin spine count is the clean division between rock bass (six) and the true sunfish (three). It is the sort of check that settles an argument on the water in five seconds.
They tell you the bottom is right	Rock bass need hard bottom. Catching them on unfamiliar structure is direct evidence that you are over rock or gravel — which is exactly where the smallmouth you actually wanted will be. <i>see the Reading Water sheet</i>
Aggressive out of proportion	An 8 in rock bass will attack a lure meant for a three-pound bass. This is a nuisance when you want bass and a gift when you have a bored child in the boat.
Age	A 9 in rock bass may be seven or eight years old — they are slow growers and longer-lived than their abundance suggests.

Prove it in hand



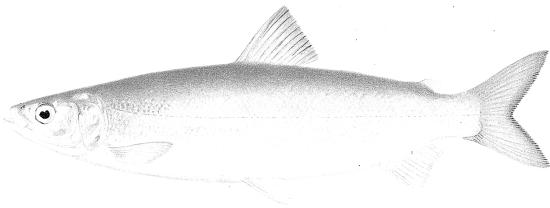
Ask first	Can you count six hard spines at the front of the anal fin?
Rule out	True sunfish such as bluegill and pumpkinseed have three anal spines; red eye alone is not decisive.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: fold the dorsal safely, press the closed snout to the stop, and read the longest tail point.
Field proof	Six anal spines plus the large mouth settle the identification even when body colour changes. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Rock Bass. Revised 20260725.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cisco

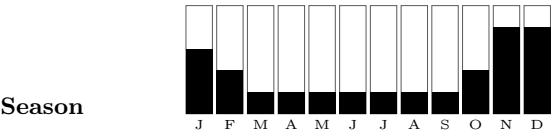
Coregonus artedii — also called lake herring

The deep-water forage fish that explains Pine Lake



Cisco from Hemlock Lake (*Argyrosomus artedii*) — plate from the Freshwater and Marine Image Bank, University of Washington. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	Slim, bright silver, deeply forked tail, small toothless mouth, and a small fleshy adipose fin between the dorsal and the tail — the mark of a salmonid. Nothing else in these lakes has one.
Size here	8–14 in.
Why it matters	Cisco need cold water that still holds oxygen through the summer. Very few lakes in south-eastern Wisconsin can supply that. Their presence is a direct statement about the quality and depth of Pine Lake’s basin.
Spawn	Very late — November into December, over shallow gravel, often as the lake is cooling toward ice.
Eats	Zooplankton, out in open water. It is a pelagic fish that almost never touches bottom or structure.



What it means for your fishing

Suspended predators	Through July and August, cisco hold in the cold layer below the thermocline over Pine Lake’s 60–85 ft basin, and the biggest walleye, pike and smallmouth follow them out there. This is why the structure bite can die in high summer while the lake is still full of large fish — they are not on the structure at all.
What to do about it	Watch your electronics over open water between spots 3 and 4 . Marks at 30–45 ft over 70 ft of water in August are usually cisco, and often something larger nearby.
Bait size	Where predators are eating a 10 in silver fish, a 3 in minnow is a poor imitation. Size up in late summer.
Catching them	Mostly incidental. They will take a small jig or spoon fished deep, and they are a known ice-fishing target on lakes that hold them. 10 per day; open all year.
Eating	Excellent, oily and fine-textured. Traditionally smoked.

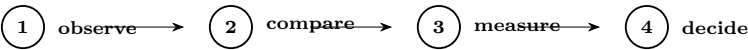
A lesson in the lake

A lake is a stack of layers, not a bowl. In summer Pine Lake has warm water on top, a sharp temperature step in the middle, and cold water below — and different fish live in each. Cisco are the clearest evidence that the bottom layer is alive. Explaining that to a child on the water is worth more than a limit of bluegill.

Worth knowing

They are a thermometer	Cisco need cold water that still holds oxygen through late summer. Their presence in Pine Lake is a direct statement that the deep basin stays oxygenated — something most lakes in southern Wisconsin cannot manage. Where cisco disappear from a lake, it is usually because that layer failed.
A salmonid, not a herring	Despite the name lake herring, the adipose fin gives it away: cisco are in the salmon and trout family. That is why they are oily and why they smoke so well. <i>see the Cooking Cisco sheet</i>
They spawn under your ice	Spawning happens in November and December over shallow gravel, sometimes as the lake is freezing — the latest spawn of any fish in this guide by months.
They filter the open water	Cisco eat zooplankton in open water, converting the smallest thing in the lake into a 10 in packet of protein that a walleye can eat. They are the link between the plankton and the predators.
Which is where the big fish go	In July and August the largest predators in Pine Lake follow cisco out over the basin, and structure fishing goes quiet while the lake is still full of fish. Watch for marks at 30–45 ft over 70 ft of water.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Is there a small fleshy adipose fin between the dorsal fin and deeply forked tail?
Rule out	Shiners and young perch lack an adipose fin; whitefish have a more projecting snout and different body depth.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: support the soft body on a wet board and read without squeezing.
Field proof	Adipose fin, forked tail, and small toothless mouth must appear together. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

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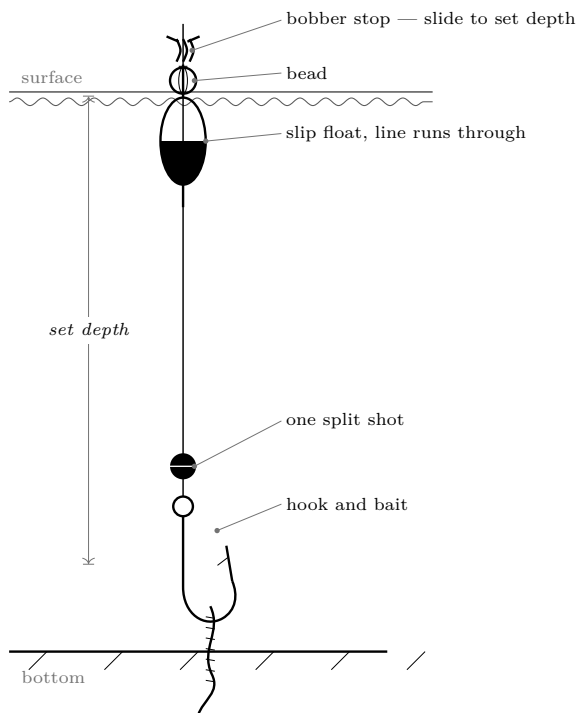
III Rigs

One page each: a drawing of the assembled rig, what every component is for, how to build it, and how to fish it. Roughly in order of how often you will tie them.

Slip Bobber

Hold a live bait at an exact depth, in any depth of water

The first rig to learn and the last one to give up



What it does	The float slides freely on the line until it hits the stop knot. You can fish 20 ft down and still reel the float to the rod tip to cast.
Why it matters	A fixed bobber can only fish as deep as your rod is long. A slip float has no such limit, which is the whole reason it exists.
Components	Bobber stop (thread or rubber), small bead, slip float, one or two split shot, hook.
Hook	Size 8–10 for panfish, 4–6 for crappie on a minnow, 1/0 for bass or walleye on a leech.
Line	4 lb for panfish; 6–8 lb for bass and walleye.
Catches	Bluegill, pumpkinseed, crappie, perch, largemouth, walleye, pike.

Build it

1. Thread the **bobber stop** onto the main line and slide it up. Tighten it enough to hold but loose enough to slide when you pull — this is what you will adjust all day.
2. Thread the **bead**. Its only job is to stop the small stop knot from pulling through the float's hole.
3. Thread the **float**, top end first.
4. Pinch on **split shot** 8–12 in above where the hook will be. Enough weight that the float sits upright with only its tip showing — an over-floated bobber cannot signal a bite.
5. Tie on the **hook** with an improved clinch knot, *see the **knots** sheet*.

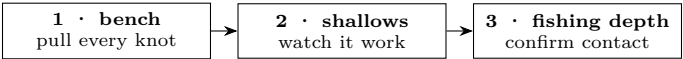
Fish it

Set the depth	Bait should ride just above whatever the fish are holding on — the weed tops, the bottom, the school. Fish look up far more readily than down. Start a foot above and work down.
Read it	A bluegill takes the float sideways and down in small taps. A crappie lifts it and lays it flat — that is a fish swimming up with the bait, and it is a bite. Walleye pull it under slowly and steadily.
Set the hook	Reel the slack, then sweep. Do not snap a rod at a crappie, <i>see the Black Crappie sheet</i> .
Adjust	A float that lies flat and stays flat is too deep — the bait is on the bottom. Slide the stop down.

When to use it

Any time you know the depth and want the bait to stay there: over a weed edge, over a crappie school suspended at 14 ft, over a bluegill bed, or with a big sucker over a weed flat for pike. It is the most controllable live-bait presentation there is, and it is the easiest rig in this guide to hand to a beginner.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

Slide the stop through every rod guide, pull the hook knot, and measure stop-to-hook depth against the rod or a tape.
- Water test

Set it two feet deep beside the boat: line must pass through the float until the stop seats and the float stands upright.
- Proof at depth

After the cast, time the float seating; failure to stand means bottom contact, fouling, or insufficient shot.
- If it fails

Float lies flat: add shot incrementally. Stop slips: retie or double it. Bait buries in weed: shorten set depth six inches. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

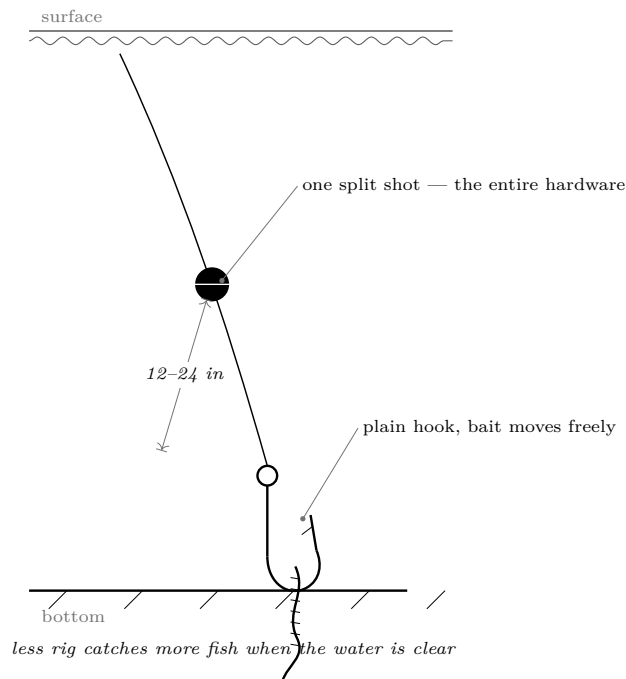
Reason and next prediction

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Split Shot Rig

The least rig you can get away with — and often the best

A hook, a pinch of lead, and nothing else



What it does	One small weight pinched on the line 12–24 in above a plain hook. It gives just enough weight to cast and to sink, and leaves the bait free to move naturally.
Why it matters	Every other rig on these sheets adds hardware, and hardware adds unnatural motion. When fish are wary, less rig catches more fish.
Components	A hook. A split shot. That is all.
Shot size	BB or size 5 for panfish; size 3 or larger, or two shot, for bass and smallmouth in deeper water.
Removable shot	Buy the kind with wings on the back so you can reopen and reposition them. You will move the shot constantly.
Catches	Everything. Rock bass, perch, bluegill, smallmouth on a live crayfish, walleye on a leech.

Fish it

1. Pinch one shot on the line, using pliers or your teeth — but never on fluorocarbon leader you care about, because crimping weakens it at that point.
2. Cast out and let it sink on a semi-tight line, watching where the line enters the water.
3. Retrieve in slow, small pulls with long pauses, or simply let it sit on the bottom and wait.
4. Move the shot to change how the bait behaves: closer to the hook makes it sink faster and act tighter, further away lets it drift and swim more freely.

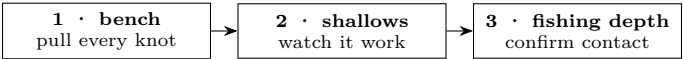
Where it beats a better rig

Wary fish	Pine Lake in flat calm. A single small shot is less unnatural than a jig head or a bullet weight.
Live crayfish	Hook one through the tail with a plain hook and one shot, and drift it across gravel at Pine spots 2, 3 or 4 . Very few smallmouth refuse it.
Teaching	Two components and no rigging. A child can build it in twenty seconds and understand what every part does.
Repair	When you snap off the fancy rig in a rock pile and the light is going, this is the rig you can retie in the dark.
Not for	Heavy weed — the exposed hook fouls. Use a <i>see the Texas rig sheet</i> there instead.

When to use it

Whenever you catch yourself adding hardware to solve a problem that is actually caused by hardware. Start every unfamiliar spot with a split shot and a piece of live bait: it tells you what lives there before you commit to a technique.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

Pull the hook knot and pinch the shot only enough to hold; tug it against a ruler mark to prove it does not slide.
- Water test

Drop beside the boat: bait should sink slowly ahead of slack line, not spiral.
- Proof at depth

You can still feel occasional bottom contact without the bait pinning there.
- If it fails

Shot slides: replace it rather than crushing line harder. Bait spins: hook it straighter. Too fast: use a smaller shot or move it farther from the hook. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

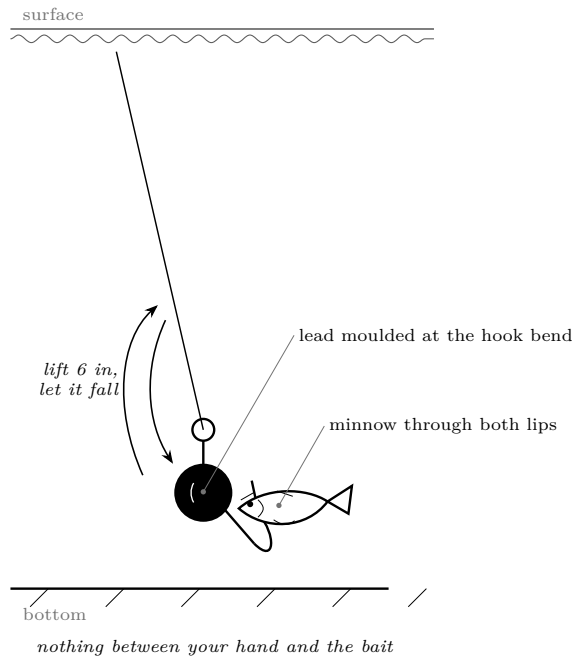
Reason and next prediction

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Jig and Minnow

One hook, one weight, one piece of bait

The simplest way to put a bait exactly where a walleye is



What it does	Weight and hook in one piece, so you feel everything and control the depth absolutely. There is nothing between your hand and the bait.
Why it matters	In cold water a walleye's take is a barely perceptible change in weight. A jig transmits that; almost nothing else does.
Weight	1/8 oz to 15 ft, 1/4 oz to 25 ft, 3/8 oz deeper or in wind. Use the lightest head that still lets you feel bottom.
Head shape	Round for vertical work; a stand-up head for dragging on a clean bottom.
Bait	A 2-3 in fathead or shiner hooked up through both lips. A half crawler or a leech works in warmer water.
Line	6-8 lb. Braid with a fluorocarbon leader if you want maximum feel in deep water.

Fish it

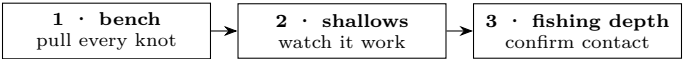
1. Lower or cast, and let it fall on a **semi-tight** line. Watch and feel — a good share of bites happen on the initial drop, and on a fully slack line you will never know.
2. When it hits bottom, lift the rod tip about six inches and **let it fall back under control**, following it down with the rod. The fall is the presentation. The lift only sets up the next fall.
3. Pause on the bottom for a two-count. Repeat.
4. If you are casting, work the jig back with the same lift-and-fall while the boat holds on the contour.

Reading the bite

The classic take	You lift and the jig feels <i>heavy</i> — as though you picked up a wet leaf. That is a walleye. Sweep the rod immediately.
The tick	A single sharp tap on the fall. Set at once.
Nothing	Sometimes the jig simply stops falling early. Set.
Do not snap	A firm upward sweep sets a single sharp hook. A violent snap tears it out of a soft mouth.
Stay vertical	Keep the line as close to straight up and down as the drift allows. Line at an angle costs you feel and costs you hooksets.
Where	Pine spots 2, 3, 4 and 8 ; North spots 2, 3 and 4 . 15-35 ft.

When to use it
Cold water — ice-out through May, and again from October on — and any time you can see fish on electronics and want to put something on their heads. It is also the best rig for teaching feel, because everything that happens to the jig arrives in your hand.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

Pull the knot hard, align it at the top of the jig eye, and confirm the minnow lies straight rather than corkscrewed.
- Water test

Drop in clear water: the jig falls head-first and the minnow tracks without spinning.
- Proof at depth

You can name each bottom contact; if not, step from 1/8 to 1/4 oz before changing cadence.
- If it fails

Snagging constantly: hold the rod higher and shorten hops. No bottom signal: remove line bow or add one weight step. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

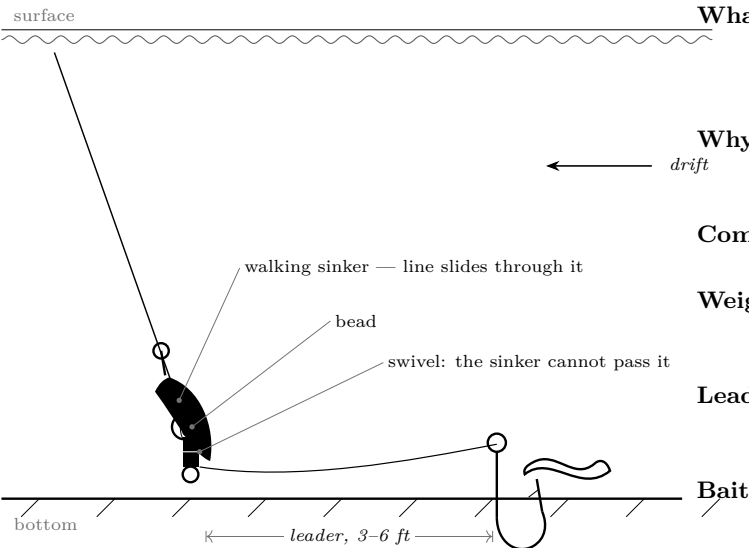
Reason and next prediction

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Lindy Rig

Drag live bait along the bottom and let the fish take line

The walleye rig — also called a slip-sinker or live-bait rig



What it does	The sinker drags the bottom; the line slides <i>through</i> it. When a fish picks up the bait it feels no weight at all, so it keeps moving instead of dropping the bait.
Why it matters	A cold-water walleye mouths a bait and spits anything that resists. This rig removes the resistance.
Components	Walking or egg sinker, bead, barrel swivel, 3–6 ft leader, single hook.
Weight	1/4 oz to 20 ft, 3/8 oz to 30 ft, 1/2 oz deeper or in wind. Use the lightest that keeps bottom contact.
Leader	Long and light in Pine Lake’s clear water — 6 ft of 6 lb fluorocarbon. Shorter and heavier on North Lake.
Bait	Leech, half a nightcrawler, or a lively minnow hooked through the lips.

Build it

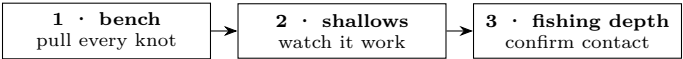
1. Thread the **sinker** onto the main line, narrow end first, so the line runs freely through it.
2. Add a **bead** to protect the knot from the sinker.
3. Tie the main line to one eye of a **barrel swivel**. The swivel is the stop: the sinker rides above it and cannot reach the hook.
4. Tie the **leader** to the other eye, then the **hook** to the leader.

Fish it

Speed	Slower than feels right. Drift with the wind or use the electric motor at a crawl — roughly the speed you would walk a dog that keeps stopping.
Contact	You must feel the sinker ticking bottom. If you cannot, add weight; if it is plowing, take weight off.
The take	You will feel weight, or a tap, or simply nothing where there was bottom a moment ago. Do not set the hook.
Feed it	Open the bail or drop the rod tip and give the fish line for a slow count of five to ten. The fish is turning the bait to swallow it head first.
Then set	Close the bail, reel until the line comes tight, and sweep the rod. No snap.
Follow the contour	Keep the boat on one depth line. A walleye break is a line, not a spot.

When to use it
Pine Lake spots 3 and 8 , North Lake spot 3 , in 18–35 ft. It is the highest-percentage way to catch a walleye on either lake, and it doubles as a smallmouth and perch rig. It is also the rig that most rewards patience: the whole thing depends on giving line to a fish that has not yet decided to keep your bait.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

Pull both swivel knots, slide the sinker freely, and measure the leader at 3–6 ft rather than by arm span.
- Water test

Tow beside the boat: sinker walks bottom while bait follows upright and does not spin.
- Proof at depth

With the rod low, feel intermittent ticks and confirm the sinker still slides when line is fed.
- If it fails

No ticks: add the next weight size. Bait spins: rehook it straight or slow down. Frequent weed: shorten the leader. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

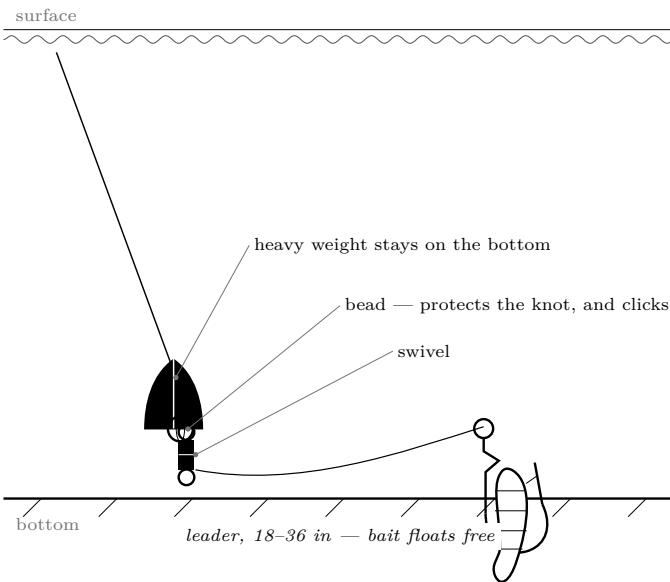
☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

Reason and next prediction

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What it does

Versus Texas

Components

The bead

Leader length

Line

A heavy weight stays on the bottom and telegraphs exactly what the bottom is made of, while the bait trails behind on a long leader, floating free.

A Texas rig puts the weight *at* the bait; a Carolina rig separates them. Texas gets into cover; Carolina covers ground and keeps the bait visible.

3/8–3/4 oz weight, glass or brass bead, barrel swivel, 18–36 in leader, offset hook, soft plastic.

Sits between weight and swivel. It protects the knot and it clicks — an audible attractor on a hard bottom.

Short (18 in) in cold water or heavy weed; long (36 in) in clear water and on a clean bottom.

15 lb main, 10–12 lb leader, so a snag breaks off the bait and not the whole rig.

Build it

1. Thread the **weight** onto the main line, then the **bead**.

2. Tie the main line to a **barrel swivel**.

3. Tie the **leader** to the other end of the swivel, then the **hook** to the leader.

4. Rig the plastic weedless exactly as for a *see the **Texas rig** sheet*, or on an open hook if the bottom is clean.

Fish it

Cast long

Drag, do not hop

Feel the bottom

The bite

Where

This is a long-cast rig. The weight carries it, and the long leader means it needs a slow, wide casting stroke or it will tangle.

Sweep the rod sideways, low and slow, to drag the weight across the bottom. Reel up the slack, reposition, sweep again.

You are mapping structure by touch. Sand feels smooth, gravel grinds, rock knocks, weeds load and release. Slow down when the bottom changes — that is where fish are.

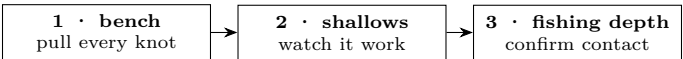
Usually a distinct tick or a mushy weight. Reel down until tight, then sweep. Do not snap.

Pine spot **5** on the outside weed edge, and the flats around the base of the bar at **4**. North spots **3** and **4**.

When to use it

When you need to find fish on a big, featureless-looking flat. The Carolina rig is a search tool that happens to catch fish: it tells you where the bottom changes, and bass live where the bottom changes.

Prove the rig



Bench test	Pull main-line knot and leader knot separately; the swivel must turn and the bead must remain above it.
Water test	Drag beside the boat: the sinker should tick bottom while the plastic trails freely without spinning.
Proof at depth	Count distinct bottom taps; no taps means too light, continuous plowing means too heavy.
If it fails	Leader wraps the main line: shorten to 18 in or slow the cast. Weed fouls the bait: peg nothing; shorten leader and inspect every retrieve. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict ☐ repeat unchanged ☐ alter one variable ☐ retire or repair the rig

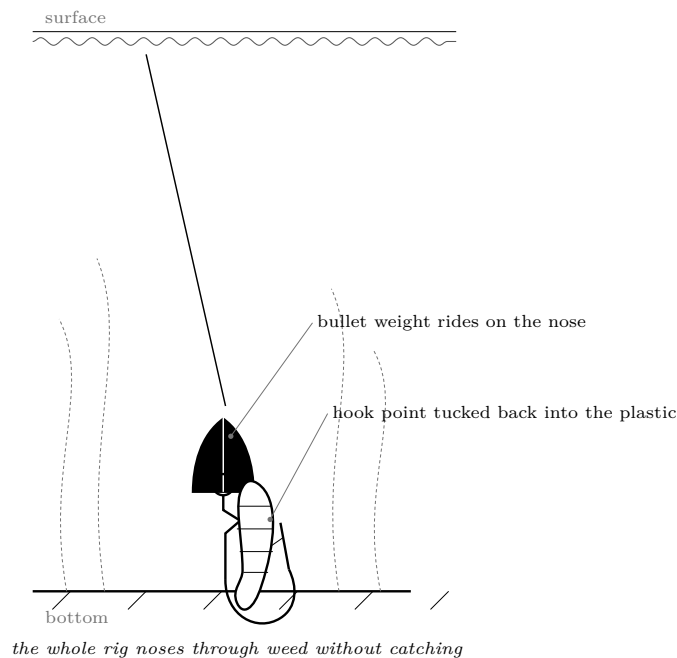
Reason and next prediction

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Texas Rig

The weedless bass rig

Put a soft plastic inside heavy cover without hanging up



What it does	A cone-shaped weight slides down to the nose of a soft plastic, and the hook point is tucked back inside the plastic body. The whole thing noses through weed, wood and rock without catching.
Why it matters	Largemouth live inside cover. Any rig that hangs up in cover cannot reach them.
Components	Bullet weight, optional peg or bobber stop, offset worm hook, soft plastic.
Weight	1/8 oz over sparse weed, 1/4–3/8 oz to punch through thick stuff. Lighter falls slower and gets more bites.
Hook	3/0–4/0 offset worm hook for a 6 in worm; 4/0–5/0 for a creature bait.
Line	12–15 lb. You are pulling fish out of salad; this is not the place for 6 lb.

Rig the plastic — this is the whole trick

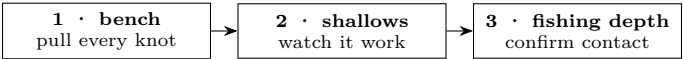
1. Slide the **bullet weight** on, point first, then tie on the hook. Peg the weight with a bobber stop if you want it to stay at the nose in heavy cover; leave it free to slide if you want the bait to fall away from the weight.
2. Push the hook point into the exact centre of the worm’s nose and out the side after about **1/4 inch**. Not more.
3. Slide the worm up over the hook eye and onto the line.
4. Rotate the hook 180 degrees so the point faces the worm’s body.
5. Lay the hook alongside the worm to see where the point lands, then push it through at that spot and back out — then **pull it back** until the point just sits under the plastic skin. The worm must hang perfectly straight. A worm with a kink in it spins and fish will not eat it.

Fish it

Cast and watch	Most bites come on the initial fall. Watch your line where it enters the water — if it jumps, twitches, or stops falling early, set the hook.
Work it	Lift the rod tip slowly to drag the bait a foot, then let it fall back on a controlled slack line. Repeat. You are feeling for weight, not waiting for a tug.
Set hard	Unlike every other rig on this sheet, this one needs a hard, fast, upward set — you have to drive the point out through the plastic and into bone.
Where	Pine spots 5 and 6 , North spots 1 and 7 . Into the weeds, not along them.

When to use it
When the fish are <i>in</i> cover rather than beside it: matted weed, laydowns, dock pilings, the inside edge of a weed bed on a hot afternoon. If you can fish an open weed edge, a <i>see the Carolina rig sheet</i> covers water faster — but nothing else gets into the thick stuff and comes back out.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

Pull the knot, then run the rig across cloth: hook point and barb must remain buried or skin-hooked with a straight worm body.
- Water test

Swim it beside the boat: the worm falls straight, weight first, without rolling.
- Proof at depth

Each lift produces a clean fall and a distinct bottom stop; inspect the point after every heavy contact.
- If it fails

Worm corkscrews: reinsert the hook on the centerline. Weed catches at the eye: peg the weight. Missed fish: expose the point lightly. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

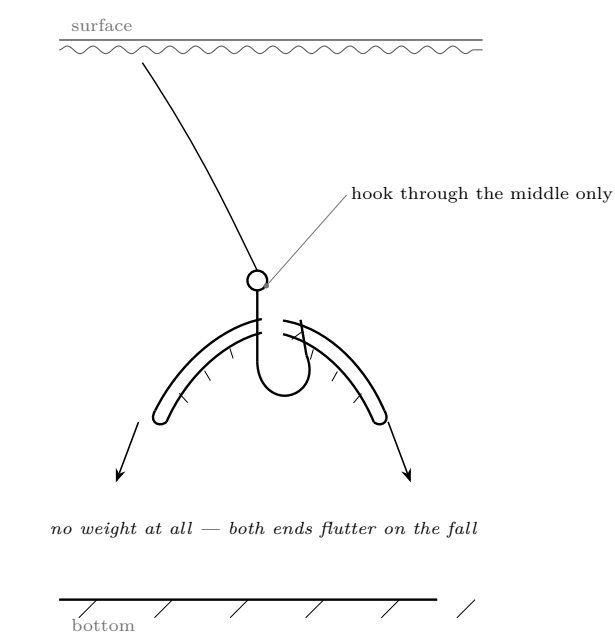
☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

Reason and next prediction

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- What it does

A straight soft-plastic worm hooked through its middle, with no weight at all. On the fall both halves shimmy independently. Nothing else in fishing moves like it.
- Why it works

It falls slowly, horizontally, and looks alive while doing nothing. In water as clear as Pine Lake’s, a slow horizontal fall beats an active retrieve.
- Components

One 1/0 or 2/0 octopus or wide-gap hook, one 5 in stick worm. That is the entire rig.
- O-ring

Slide a small rubber O-ring onto the worm’s middle and hook under the ring instead of through the plastic. One worm then lasts twenty fish instead of two.
- Line

6–10 lb. Spinning tackle. Fluorocarbon leader on Pine Lake.
- Catches

Largemouth above all; smallmouth and big bluegill will take it too.

Fish it

1. Cast past the target — a dock, a weed clump, an edge — and **do nothing**.
2. Watch the line. The worm is falling on a slack line and almost every bite happens here. If the line twitches, jumps, or stops falling, reel down and sweep.
3. If it reaches the bottom untouched, give the rod two small shakes, then let it sit for a slow count of five.
4. Lift, let it fall again, and repeat. Retrieve slowly and cast again.

Getting it right

- Patience

The single most common mistake is fishing it too fast. This rig catches fish while it is doing nothing. If you feel like you are wasting time, you are probably fishing it correctly.
- Watch the line

You will not feel most bites. You will see them. Keep a slight bow in the line and keep your eyes on where it enters the water.
- Wind

The one condition it hates. In a chop you cannot see the line; switch to a *see the Texas rig sheet* or a jig.
- Where

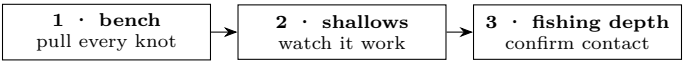
Pine spots **5**, **6** and **7** — especially in bright, calm, high-sun conditions when nothing else produces. North spots **1** and **7**.
- Hookset

A firm sweep, not a snap. The hook is exposed; it does not need to be driven through plastic.

When to use it

Bright sun, flat calm, clear water, pressured fish — exactly the conditions where everyone else stops catching. On Pine Lake in July this is the highest-percentage bass presentation on the sheet, and it takes ten seconds to tie.

Prove the rig



Bench test	Pull the knot, center the hook through the O-ring or exact worm midpoint, and compare both hanging ends for equal length.
Water test	Drop beside the boat: both ends must pulse independently while the worm falls level, not nose-first.
Proof at depth	Watch line angle and count sink time to the target depth; repeatable time is proof the bait is falling clean.
If it fails	One end dominates: recenter the hook. Worm tears: use an O-ring. No visible fall: shorten the cast or use high-visibility main line with a clear leader. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict ☐ repeat unchanged ☐ alter one variable ☐ retire or repair the rig

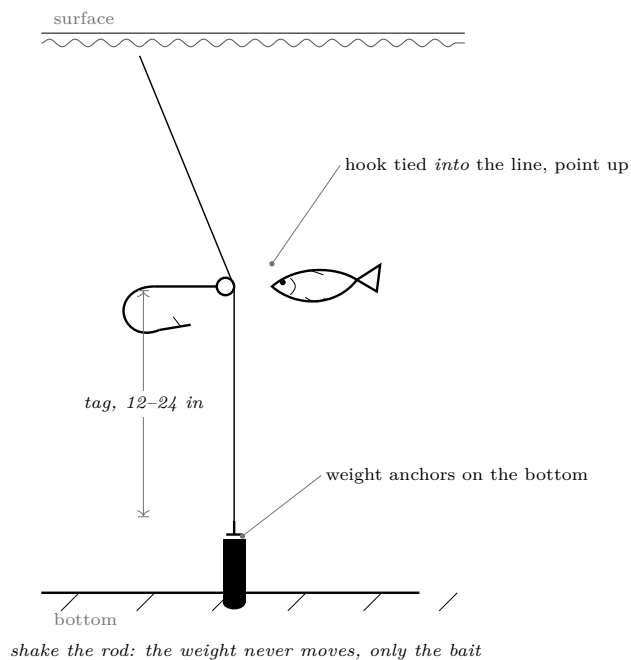
Reason and next prediction

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Wacky Rig. Revised 20260725.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Drop Shot

Weight on the bottom, bait suspended above it, both under your control

*The deep-water finesse rig — weight below
the hook*



What it does	Everything else puts the weight above the bait. This puts it below. The weight anchors on the bottom and the bait hovers a fixed distance above it, where you can shake it in place indefinitely without moving it.
Why it matters	Fish that will not chase will still eat something that hangs in front of them. This is the rig for a tough day in deep clear water.
Components	Cylinder or teardrop weight, size 1 or 1/0 drop-shot hook, small minnow-shaped plastic.
Tag length	12 in for bottom-hugging perch and smallmouth; 24-36 in for fish suspended off a drop.
Line	6-8 lb fluorocarbon on spinning tackle.
Catches	Smallmouth, walleye, perch, crappie, largemouth. On Pine Lake's east wall it is the most reliable summer rig there is.

Build it

1. Tie a **Palomar knot** with the hook, but leave a very long tag end — 2 to 3 ft.
2. Pass that tag end **back down through the hook eye**, from the top. This is the step everyone forgets, and it is what makes the hook stand out from the line at right angles with the point up.
3. Attach the **weight** to the bottom of the tag with a simple overhand loop, or crimp it into the weight's line clip so it pulls free on a snag instead of costing you the rig.
4. Nose-hook the plastic through the very tip so it hangs horizontally and free.

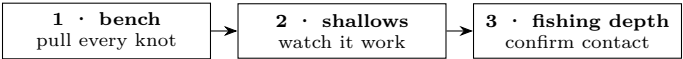
Fish it

Drop straight down	This is primarily a vertical rig. Get over the fish and lower it.
Feel the weight land	Once it is down, take up slack until the line is just tight to the weight, and then stop reeling.
Shake, do not lift	Shake the rod tip. The weight never moves; only the bait quivers. That is the entire presentation, and you can do it in one spot for a minute at a time.
The bite	Often just added weight, or the line moving sideways. Reel down and sweep — no snap, small hook.
Where	Pine spots 3 (the east wall) and 4 (down the sides of the bar), 25-40 ft. North spots 3 and 4 .

When to use it

August on Pine Lake, when the fish are deep, the sun is high and nothing is chasing. It is also the best rig in the guide for fishing a spot you can see on electronics: put it on their nose and leave it there.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

Pull the Palomar, then hold the line vertical: hook point must face up at a right angle; re-thread the tag if it does not.
- Water test

Lower beside the boat and shake slack line: bait quivers while the cylinder stays planted.
- Proof at depth

The line alternates tight/slack without the weight leaving bottom; mark the 12–24 in tag against a ruler.
- If it fails

Hook hangs point-down: tag was passed through the wrong side. Weight hops: add weight or reduce rod movement. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

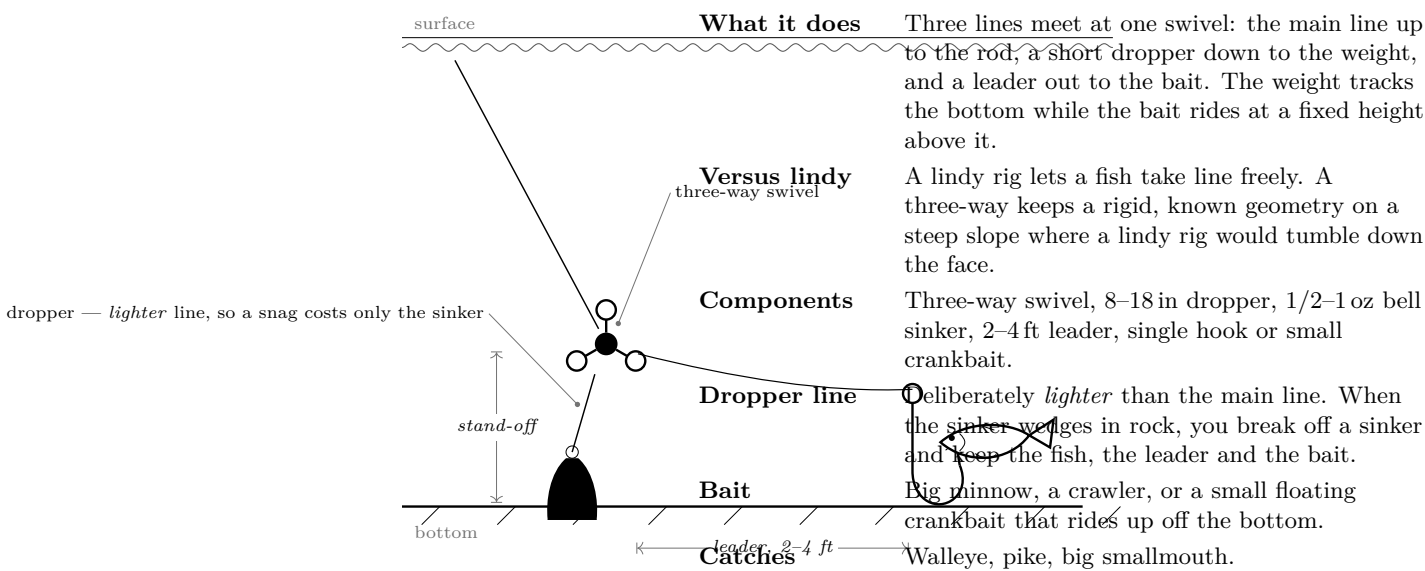
Reason and next prediction

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Three-Way Rig

Hold a precise depth on a steep face where nothing else will

Also called a wolf river rig



Build it

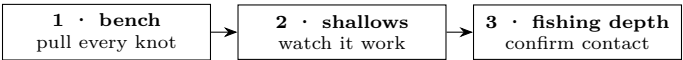
1. Tie the **main line** to the top eye of the three-way swivel.
2. Tie a short **dropper** of lighter line to the bottom eye, and the **sinker** to its end. Make the dropper as long as you want the bait to ride above the bottom.
3. Tie the **leader** to the third eye, then the hook or lure to the leader.

Fish it

Troll or drift slowly	Move at a walking pace with the sinker just ticking bottom. The rig is designed to be moving.
Vertical line	Keep the line close to straight down. Let line out until you touch bottom, then take up a few inches. Re-check constantly on a slope — that is the whole point of the rig.
Feel for the change	You are following a contour. When the sinker stops touching, you have moved deep; when it drags hard, you have moved shallow. Steer to keep contact.
Set	A steady sweep. The fish usually hooks itself against the moving boat.
Where	Pine spot 3 — the east wall is the exact situation this rig was invented for — and the steep side of the bar at 4 . North spot 3 .

When to use it
On a drop too steep to fish any other way. If you keep losing bottom contact and then plowing, alternately, on a sharp break, this is the rig. It also lets you fish a floating crankbait a fixed 18 inches off the rocks, which is deadly on fall walleye.

Prove the rig



Bench test	Pull all three knots separately; measure the 8–18 in dropper and 2–4 ft leader, with the weakest line on the sinker branch.
Water test	Tow beside the boat: sinker branch hangs below while the bait leader streams clear without wrapping.
Proof at depth	The sinker taps continuously enough to map the face while the bait remains above it.
If it fails	Branches twist: shorten the bait leader or lower more slowly. No taps: add weight. Repeated sinker loss is acceptable only if the weak dropper breaks cleanly. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

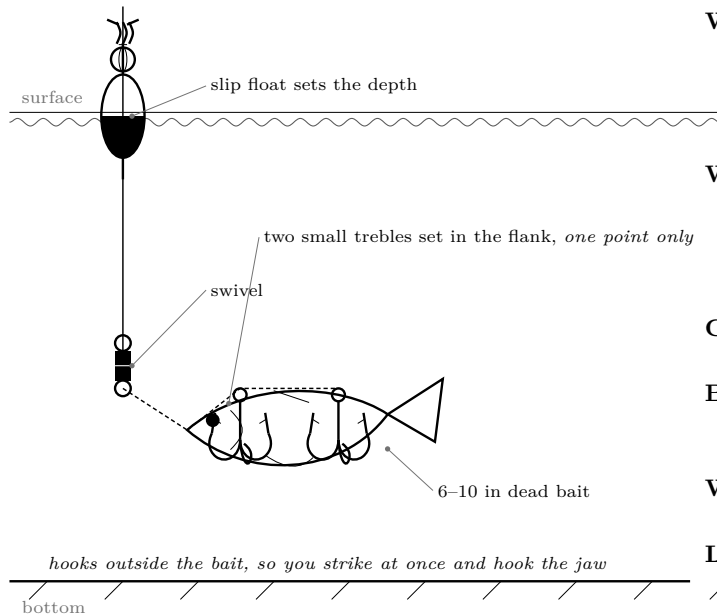
Evidence-based verdict ☐ repeat unchanged ☐ alter one variable ☐ retire or repair the rig

Reason and next prediction

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Quick-Strike Rig

Fish a big dead bait for pike and hook the fish, not its stomach



What it does	Two small treble hooks set into the flank of a large dead bait, on a wire trace. Because the hooks are on the <i>outside</i> of the bait, you strike immediately instead of waiting for the pike to swallow.
Why it matters	The old method — a single hook inside a bait, and a long wait — gut-hooks pike and kills fish you meant to release. A quick-strike rig hooks them in the jaw. This is the humane way to do it, and it is also more effective.
Components	Wire trace with two size 6–8 trebles, barrel swivel, slip float and stop, large dead bait.
Bait	A dead sucker, smelt or large shiner, 6–10 in. Dead bait works: pike scavenge readily, especially in cold water.
Wire	Not optional. Pike teeth cut monofilament instantly.
Line	20 lb braid or 15 lb mono; a rod with backbone.

Build and bait it

1. Rig the **slip float** on the main line — stop knot, bead, float — exactly as on the *see the slip bobber sheet* sheet. Set the depth so the bait hangs just above the weed tops.
2. Tie the main line to a **barrel swivel**, and the swivel to the **wire trace**.
3. Set the **rear treble** into the bait's flank near the tail, one point only, barely under the skin.
4. Set the **front treble** near the head, again one point only. The bait should hang naturally, not bent.

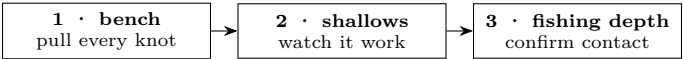
Fish it

Strike early	When the float goes down, count to five , reel until tight, and sweep hard. Do not give it a minute. Do not give it thirty seconds. The whole design assumes an early strike.
Tackle at hand	Long-nose pliers, side cutters and jaw spreaders in the boat before you cast, not after you hook one.
Cut, do not dig	If a hook is awkward, cut the treble with side cutters and back the pieces out. A cheap hook is worth less than the fish.
Where	Pine spots 1 and 9 in April and again in October; the deep weed edge at 5 in summer. North spots 2 , 5 and 6 .
Ice	The same rig on a tip-up is the standard big-pike presentation, <i>see the tip-up sheet</i> .

HANDLE PIKE PROPERLY

Backward-facing teeth, and a fish strong enough to thrash while you work. Jaw spreaders and long pliers every time; fingers never inside the mouth or under the gill plate. Pike over 70 °F water are fragile — unhook in the net, in the water, and release quickly. See the **Northern Pike** sheet.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

With hook covers on, pull every crimp and wire connection; set the two trebles the measured distance apart for the bait.
- Water test

Suspend the dead bait beside the hole: it must hang horizontal, with both hook points exposed and the float carrying the load.
- Proof at depth

The float cocks consistently at the stop and the bait remains above weed, not buried in it.
- If it fails

Bait hangs nose-down: move the front hook toward the head. Float sinks: increase capacity. Never fish if a crimp slips under a hard hand pull. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

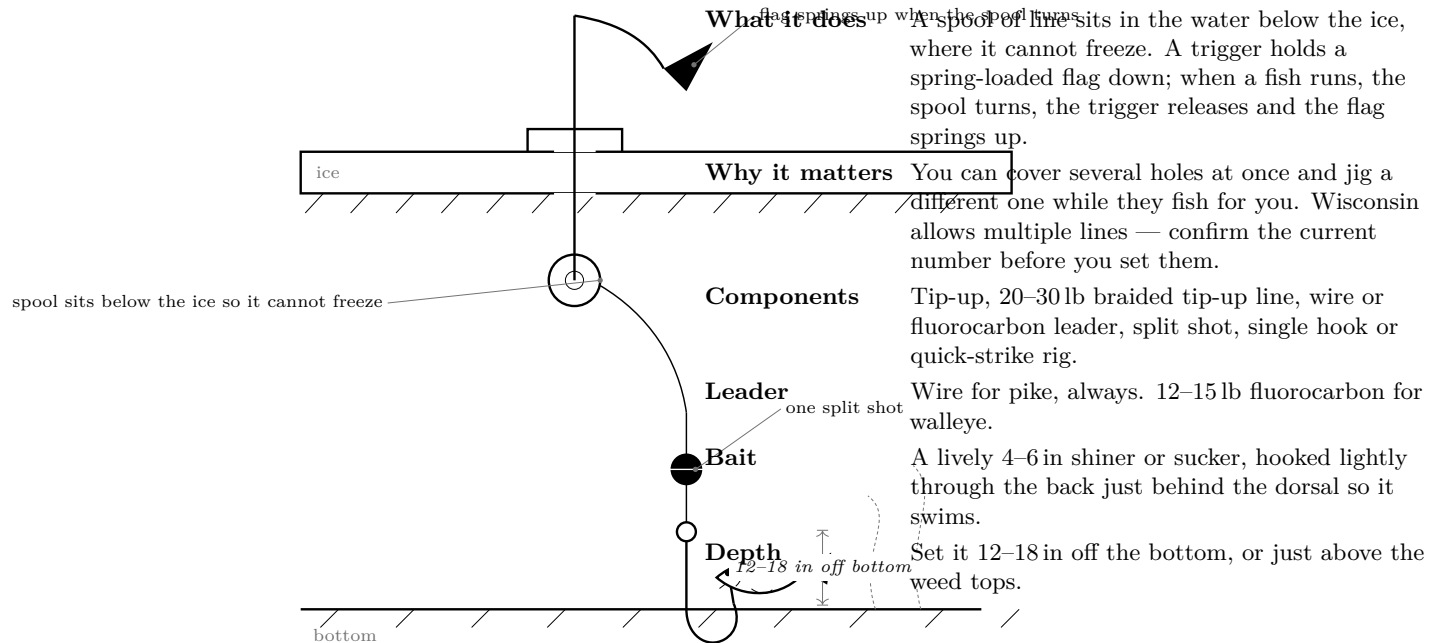
Reason and next prediction

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Tip-Up

Winter pike and walleye

Fish live bait under the ice while you fish somewhere else



Set it

1. Drill the hole and clear the slush completely, or the flag will freeze down and never trip.
2. Drop the baited rig until it touches bottom, then reel up 12–18 in and mark that line depth with a rubber band or a clip so you can reset the same depth all day.
3. Set the trigger with the flag bent under it. Test it once by hand — a trigger set too tight will not release for a fish.
4. Bank snow around the base of the tip-up to keep the hole from refreezing.

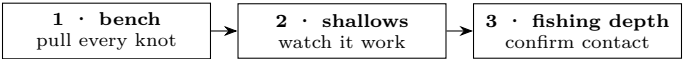
When the flag goes

Walk, do not run	Footsteps on clear ice carry. Approach quietly, especially in shallow water.
Watch the spool	If it is still turning, the fish is moving. Let it run. If it has stopped, wait until it starts again — that is the fish turning the bait.
Set by hand	Pick the line up off the spool, take up slack until you feel the fish, and pull firmly hand over hand. There is no rod to absorb a snap, so a smooth strong pull is correct.
Bring it up hand over hand	Lay line on the ice away from the hole so it cannot tangle back down.
Where	Pine spots 1 , 6 and 9 over weed edges in 8–15 ft; North spots 1 and 5 . Pike season closes 7 March — check the current dates.

ICE IS NEVER GUARANTEED

No ice is safe ice. Check thickness yourself as you go rather than trusting somebody else's report; four inches of clear ice is a common minimum for one person on foot, and more for a group. Springs, inlets, outlets and current thin the ice unpredictably — on North Lake the river inflow and outflow at spots **2** and **6** are exactly the places to stay off. Carry ice picks around your neck, take a rope, and do not go out alone.

Prove the rig



- Bench test

Pull leader and hook knots, cycle the spool and trip arm ten times, and verify the flag releases without line drag.
- Water test

In the hole, lower the bait just below view: it must swim freely while the spool turns without sticking.
- Proof at depth

Sound depth with a clip-on weight, then set bait a measured 1–3 ft above bottom and record the arm-length reference.
- If it fails

False flags: reduce trigger sensitivity or shelter from wind. No spool turn on a run: clear ice and line overlap before resetting. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict

☐ repeat unchanged

☐ alter one variable

☐ retire or repair the rig

Reason and next prediction

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IV Reference

Why fish are where they are, what to carry, when to go, the four knots that cover everything here, how to put a fish back so it lives, and how to take somebody out for the first time.

Reading Water

*The sheet that makes the other sheets
portable*

Why fish are where they are, so you can find them on any lake

Every numbered spot in this guide was chosen by the same reasoning, and once you can do that reasoning yourself you no longer need the numbers. Fish are not distributed evenly. They stack up wherever two things meet.

The one idea: fish live on edges

What an edge is	Any place where the water changes — shallow to deep, weed to open, hard bottom to soft, warm to cold, bright to shaded, current to still. An edge gives a predator cover on one side and hunting ground on the other, and it concentrates the food chain from the bottom up.
The best spots have two	A weed edge is good. A weed edge on a point is better. A weed edge on a point next to a fast drop into deep water is where everything in the lake eventually shows up. Pine Lake's mid-lake bar is four edges stacked in one place, which is why it is spot 4.
The featureless middle	A flat, uniform bottom in open water holds almost nothing. If you cannot name the edge you are fishing, you are probably not fishing anything.

The edges worth finding, in order

Edge	Why fish use it	On these lakes
Break (drop-off)	A fish can move between shallow feeding and deep safety without crossing open water. The steeper the break, the less distance that move costs, so steep breaks hold fish through more of the day.	Pine 3 (east wall), 8; North 3, 7
Weed edge	The outside line where weed growth stops for lack of light. Bait hides inside it, predators patrol outside it. In clear water it is deep; in stained water it is shallow.	Pine 5 at 12–18 ft; North 1 at 6–10 ft
Point	A finger of shallow ground reaching into deep water. It intercepts fish moving along a shoreline and it catches wind. Fish the <i>end</i> , not the sides.	Pine 2, 8; North 3
Bar or hump	Shallow structure isolated in deep water. The best of all, because it is the only cover for a long way and fish have to commit to it.	Pine 4; North 4
Inside turn	A notch where the depth line bends back toward shore. Fish moving along a break funnel into it.	Pine 2, 7; North 2
Neck or narrows	Anywhere a lake pinches. Everything that moves between two areas passes through, and current keeps the bottom clean.	North 5
Inlet / outlet	Moving water: different temperature, oxygen, and a constant delivery of food. First place to look in early spring and late fall.	Pine 9; North 2, 6
Wind-blown shore	Wind pushes plankton against a bank, then baitfish, then predators. Uncomfortable to fish, which is exactly why it is uncrowded.	Whichever side the wind is on
Shade line	The edge of a dock, an overhanging tree, a weed mat. A fish in shade sees out; you cannot see in. Midday, high sun.	Pine 6, 7; North 1

The invisible edge: the thermocline

What happens	By early summer a deep lake settles into three layers: a warm mixed layer on top, a thin band where temperature falls sharply — the thermocline — and cold, dense water below.
Why it matters	The layers stop mixing. Below the thermocline, oxygen is no longer being replenished. In most lakes that makes the deep water uninhabitable by midsummer, so <i>every fish in the lake</i> is squeezed into the water above it.
Pine Lake is the exception	It is deep and clean enough to keep oxygen in the cold layer, which is why it holds cisco. That means predators here have somewhere to go that most lakes do not — and in July and August they go there. <i>see the Cisco sheet</i>
How to find it	On sonar it is often a faint horizontal band of clutter. Or lower a thermometer: where the reading drops several degrees in a couple of feet, that is it. Typically 15–25 ft in this part of Wisconsin.
Turnover	In autumn the surface cools until the layers have the same density and the whole lake mixes. For a week or two the water looks cloudy and the fishing is genuinely poor. Then it is the best month of the year.

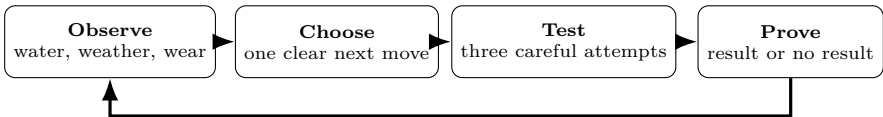
A method for a lake you have never seen

1. Look at a contour map *before* you launch and mark every point, bar, inside turn and narrows. That is your list of candidate spots and it costs nothing.
2. On the water, find the weed line first. It tells you how far light penetrates, which tells you how deep everything else will be.
3. Start shallow and early. Work out and down as the sun climbs.
4. Fish an edge, not an area. Keep the boat on one depth and follow it.
5. When you catch one, stop and note the depth, the bottom, and the edge. Then find the same combination somewhere else on the lake — fish are creatures of pattern, and the pattern repeats.

The point of the numbered spots

The nine spots on Pine Lake and the seven on North Lake are not secrets; they are worked examples. Each one is a named edge, and the lake sheets say which edge and why. Learn the reasoning and you can walk up to any lake in the county and produce your own list before you get the boat wet.

Use a closed-loop check



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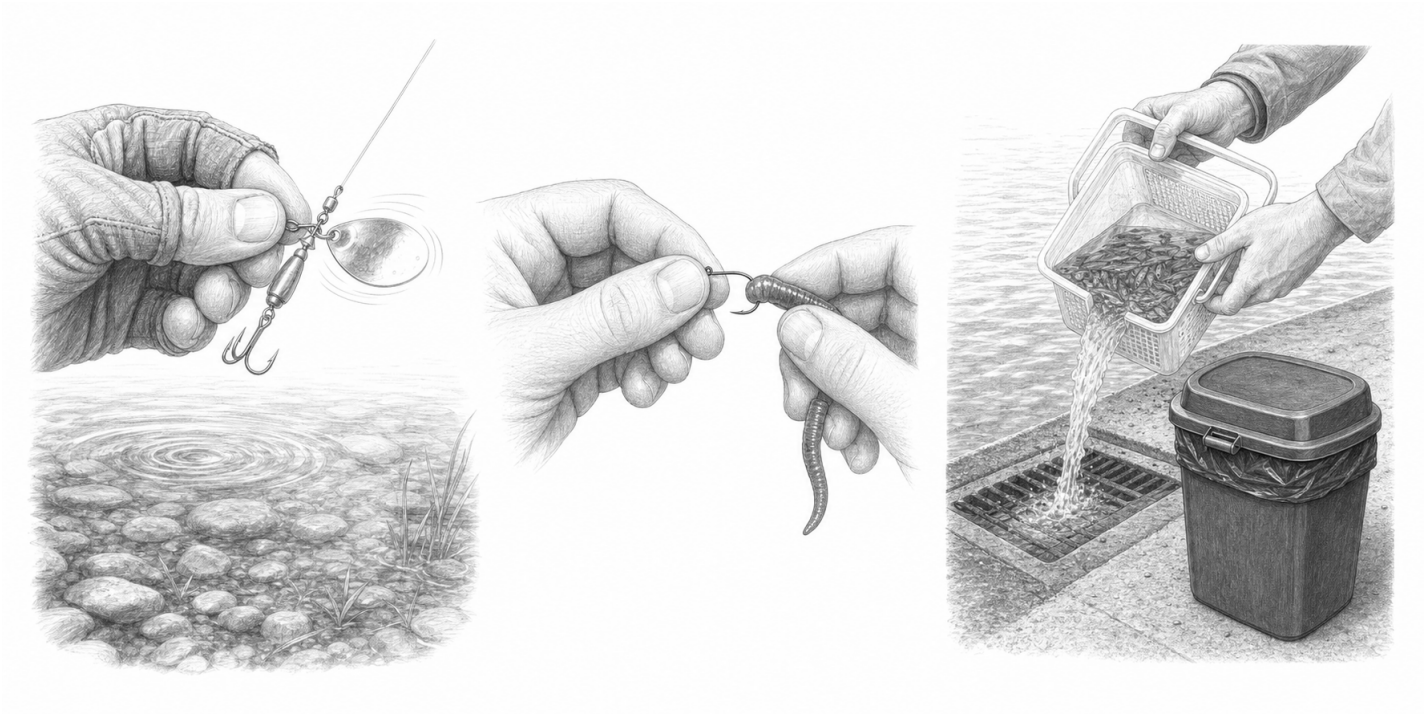
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Lures & Baits

Pine Lake & North Lake

What to carry, and what each thing is actually for

A tackle box fills up with things that catch fishermen. This sheet is the short list that catches fish on these two lakes, with the reason each item exists. Buy depth and colour variety in the few categories that matter, not one of everything.



CONFIRM BLADE ROTATION

EXPOSE ONE SHORT BAIT TAIL

DRAIN WATER; TRASH UNUSED BAIT

Choose, prove, then fish

1. Name one target species.
2. Read the lake sheet and choose one depth band.
3. Choose one lure row below that reaches that band.
4. Tie the lure directly unless its rig sheet specifies a leader or swivel.
5. Pull the knot hard with dry hands.
6. Touch the final two feet of line.
7. Replace any rough line; do not shorten past the damaged section and hope.
8. Lower the lure beside the boat or bank.
9. Move it at the intended speed.
10. Confirm the blade turns, crankbait tracks straight, jig reaches bottom, or live bait remains alive.
11. Make three casts without changing lure, depth, speed, and location together.
12. Record the result before changing exactly one variable.

Failure branches
Lure rolls or pulls sideways: inspect the eye and connection, then retire a damaged lure. Blade does not turn: increase speed briefly; if it still stalls, clear debris or replace it. Bottom is never felt: add the smallest next weight. Snags repeat: reduce depth or choose the weedless option. No contact after three controlled passes: move to the next supported edge before changing the whole tackle box.

Hard baits

Lure	Size	What it is for and how to work it	Target
Inline spinner	1/8–1/4 oz	Steady retrieve, blade turning. The simplest lure that works. Excellent for a beginner because a constant speed is all it needs.	Panfish, bass, pike
Spinnerbait	3/8–3/4 oz	Safety-pin wire arm makes it near-weedless. Slow-roll it over and through weed tops. The pike lure on North Lake.	Pike, largemouth
Squarebill crankbait	2–2.5 in	Dives 3–6 ft and deflects off cover. Bump it into weeds and rock; the strike comes as it ricochets.	Largemouth, smallmouth
Deep crankbait	2.5–3 in	Dives 12–20 ft. Trolled or cast along a break. Fall walleye.	Walleye, pike
Suspending jerkbait	4–5 in	Twitch, twitch, <i>pause</i> . The pause is the presentation — count to five in cold water.	Smallmouth, walleye, pike
Casting spoon	1/2–1 oz	Flutters on the fall. Cast, count down, retrieve in sweeps. Also the standard ice jigging spoon.	Pike, walleye
Walking topwater	4 in	Rod-tip cadence makes it swing side to side. First and last light only.	Largemouth
Popper	2–3 in	Chug, pause, chug. Over shallow weed on calm summer mornings.	Largemouth, big bluegill

Soft plastics and jigs

Item	Size	What it is for	Rig it on
Stick worm	5 in	The single most productive bass bait on Pine Lake. Buy these before anything else.	<i>see the wacky rig sheet, see the Texas rig sheet</i>
Ribbon-tail worm	7 in	More action on the fall than a stick worm; better in stained water.	<i>see the Texas rig sheet, see the Carolina rig sheet</i>
Tube	3–4 in	Spirals and puffs like a fleeing crayfish. The best smallmouth bait there is.	Tube jig head
Craw / creature	3–4 in	Bulk and appendages. Punching weed and flipping wood.	<i>see the Texas rig sheet</i>
Minnow-shaped plastic	3–4 in	Slim profile that hangs horizontally.	<i>see the drop-shot sheet</i>
Round jig head	1/16–3/8 oz	Weight and hook in one. Carry the whole range — depth dictates weight.	<i>see the jig-and-minnow sheet</i>
Panfish jig	1/32–1/16 oz	Tiny hair or plastic jig under a float or on its own.	<i>see the slip bobber sheet</i>
Bass jig & trailer	3/8–1/2 oz	Weedguard and a skirt. Slow, deliberate, big-fish bait around wood and weed edges.	Direct tie

Live bait

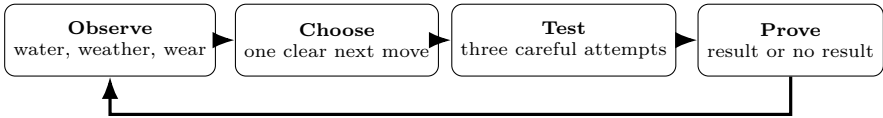
Bait	When and why	Hook it
Nightcrawler	The universal bait. Half a crawler out-fishes a whole one for panfish, because a small mouth cannot get the whole thing.	Thread on, leave a short tail moving
Leech	The best walleye bait from late May through summer. Swims with a ribbon motion nothing imitates.	Once through the sucker end
Fathead minnow	Cold water: ice-out through May, and October on. Hardy in the bucket.	Up through both lips
Golden shiner	Bigger, flashier, more fragile. Pike and walleye.	Through the back, behind the dorsal
Sucker (dead, 6–10 in)	Winter and cold-water pike. Dead bait works — pike scavenge.	see the <i>quick-strike rig sheet</i>
Waxworm / spike	Ice fishing and tight-lipped summer panfish.	One or two on a tiny jig
Crayfish	The premium smallmouth bait on Pine Lake’s gravel.	Plain hook through the tail, one split shot

Colour, in one paragraph

Pine Lake is very clear: natural and translucent colours — green pumpkin, watermelon, smoke, silver, real crayfish brown. North Lake is stained: brighter and more solid — chartreuse, white, black, gold, firetiger. In both lakes, black or dark purple is the most visible silhouette in low light and at night. If you only ever carry three soft-plastic colours, carry green pumpkin, black, and white.

Do not move live bait between waters. Wisconsin has strict rules on transporting live fish and water to prevent spreading invasive species and disease. Drain everything, and dispose of unused bait in the trash rather than the lake. Confirm the current bait rules with the DNR — they are enforced.

Use a closed-loop check



Question	Check	Recovery
What changed?	Name one visible or measurable fact: wind direction, depth, water temperature, abrasion, knot shape, lure track, fish reflex, or elapsed time.	If you cannot name the change, observe for one minute before changing equipment.
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Final proof before the next cast

Say the plan in one sentence. Tug-test the terminal connection, touch-check the last two feet of line, confirm hook point and snap closure, set the drag, and identify the safe landing and release route. If weather, visibility, footing, or fish

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Time	Place / depth	Lure / bait	Weight / rig	Speed / pause	Expected proof	Result / next one change
------	---------------	-------------	--------------	---------------	----------------	--------------------------

Chapter	Evidence / Conclusion
---------	-----------------------

Knot survives a hard pull	
Last two feet of line feel smooth	
Hook point catches lightly on a nail	
Lure runs correctly beside the bank	
Bait remains secure after one cast	
Water drained: unused bait contained	

Seasonal Calendar

Which fish, which month, which depth, which spot

Fish do not follow the calendar; they follow water temperature, and the calendar is only a rough proxy for it. A cold spring pushes everything two weeks late. Use the temperature column, not the month, whenever you can measure it.

The year by species

Species	Activity by month	Peak periods and where
Largemouth bass	Activity levels: Jan (low), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (medium), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (medium-high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (low).	May–Jun shallow, pre-spawn and spawn: Pine 6, 7; North 1, 7. Sep–Oct feeding hard on the weed edge: Pine 5; North 1.
Smallmouth bass	Activity levels: Jan (low), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (medium), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (low).	May–Jun on gravel: Pine 2, 4. Oct the best of the year: Pine 3, 4; North 4.
Walleye	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (medium).	Oct–Nov on the breaks: Pine 3, 4, 8; North 3, 4. Dawn and dusk all year.
Northern pike	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (high), Apr (high), May (medium-high), Jun (medium-high), Jul (medium), Aug (medium), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (medium-high).	Apr post-spawn in the shallows and Oct–Nov feeding up: Pine 1, 9; North 2, 6.
Bluegill	Activity levels: Jan (medium-high), Feb (medium-high), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (medium-high).	Late May–Jun on the beds: Pine 6; North 1. Deep weed edge after.
Pumpkinseed	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (medium-high).	Same beds as bluegill, slightly shallower and tighter to cover.
Black crappie	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (medium-high), Apr (high), May (high), Jun (medium-high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (high).	May near brush and Jan through the ice. Dusk always.
Yellow perch	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (high), Apr (high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (high), Aug (high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (high).	Dec–Feb the best perch fishing of the year, on the 15–30 ft flats. Daylight only.
Rock bass	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (high), Aug (high), Sep (medium-high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (medium-high).	Jun–Aug on any rock. The reliable summer fish for a child.
Cisco	Activity levels: Jan (medium-high), Feb (medium), Mar (low), Apr (low), May (low), Jun (low), Jul (low), Aug (low), Sep (low), Oct (medium-high), Nov (high), Dec (high).	Nov–Dec spawning shallow; through the ice in Jan . Pine Lake only.

The year by water temperature

Water	Roughly	What is happening, and what to do
32–40 °F	Dec–Mar	Ice. Panfish in the bays, perch on the flats, pike on tip-ups over weed edges. Everything moves slowly; small baits, long pauses.
40–45 °F	Late Mar–Apr	Ice-out. Pike spawn in flooded shallows — the first fish to go. Walleye follow onto rock. Fish the north and west shorelines, which warm first.
45–55 °F	Apr–early May	Walleye spawn and then feed. Crappie push into bays. Slow presentations, live bait, dark bottoms that hold heat.
55–65 °F	May–early Jun	Bass spawn , largemouth first and smallmouth just after. Bass season opens the first Saturday in May. The single best window of the year for numbers of fish, shallow.
65–72 °F	Jun	Panfish spawn on colonial beds. Everything is shallow and visible. This is the month to take children.
72–80 °F	Jul–Aug	The lake stratifies. Fish split: some hold the deep weed edge, some go to the hard structure, and on Pine some suspend over the basin following cisco. Fish early, late, and deep.
72–60 °F	Sep	Turnover. The surface cools, the layers mix, and for one to two weeks the fishing is genuinely poor and the water may look cloudy. Wait it out.
60–45 °F	Oct–Nov	The best fishing of the year. Big fish feed heavily and move onto structure. Larger baits, and do not be afraid to fish the middle of the day.
45–33 °F	Nov–Dec	Deep and slow. Then first ice, which is often excellent — and the most dangerous ice of the season.

Times of day

Dawn

Mid

Dusk

Night

Dawn

The most reliable hour on both lakes for almost everything. Non-negotiable in July and August.

Midday

Perch and rock bass feed; most predators do not. Bright calm midday is when finesse presentations earn their keep, *see the wacky rig sheet* and *see the drop-shot sheet*.

Dusk

The best hour for walleye and crappie. Be on the spot before the light goes rather than arriving with it.

Night

Walleye and big pike keep feeding; panfish shut down entirely.

Weather

A falling barometer ahead of a front turns fish on hard. The day after a cold front passes is the worst day of any week — go deeper, slow down, and downsize.

Wind

Wind on a point or a bar concentrates plankton, then baitfish, then predators. Fish the windy shore, not the comfortable one.

Season dates change every year. On these waters in 2026–27, gamefish open 2 May and bass, walleye and pike close 7 March; musky is open water only through 31 December; panfish are open all year. Confirm with the Wisconsin DNR before every trip.

Use a closed-loop check

```
graph LR; A[Observe  
water, weather, wear] --> B[Choose  
one clear next move]; B --> C[Test  
three careful attempts]; C --> D[Prove  
result or no result]; D --> A;
```

LAKE COUNTRY FISHING

Seasonal Calendar

3

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Knots

Learn these four and stop there

Four knots will cover everything in this guide

Every knot weakens the line it is tied in; a good knot simply weakens it less. Two habits matter more than which knot you choose: **wet it before you pull it tight**, because friction burns and permanently weakens monofilament, and **seat it slowly with steady pressure**, then look at it. A knot with a crossed wrap is a knot that will fail on the best fish of the day.

The four

Knot	Use it for	How to tie it
Improved clinch	Hook, swivel or lure to line. The everyday knot.	Pass the tag through the eye. Twist the tag around the standing line five to seven times. Pass the tag back through the small loop right at the eye, then <i>back through the large loop</i> you just created — that second pass is the “improved” part and it is what stops it slipping. Wet and pull the standing line slowly. Trim close.
Palomar	Braid to anything; the <i>see the drop-shot sheet</i> . Stronger than a clinch and harder to tie wrong.	Double about six inches of line and pass the doubled loop through the eye. Tie a loose overhand knot with the doubled line, leaving the hook hanging. Pass the loop completely <i>over</i> the hook. Wet, then pull both the standing line and the tag to seat it. Trim.
Uni (grinner)	Leader to hook; and tied twice, back to back, it joins two lines of different diameter.	Pass the tag through the eye and lay it back alongside the standing line to form a loop. Wrap the tag through that loop and around both strands five or six times. Wet and pull the tag to close the coils, then slide the whole knot down to the eye.
Double surgeon’s	Joining leader to main line quickly, including with cold hands.	Lay the two lines alongside each other, overlapping by six inches. Treating them as one, tie a simple overhand knot, then pass the same ends through a second time. Wet, and pull all four ends at once. Trim both tags.

Getting them right

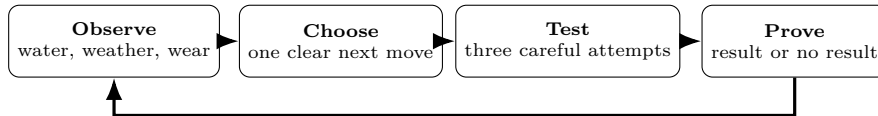
Wet every knot	Saliva or water, every time, before the final pull. A dry-cinched mono knot can lose a third of its strength to friction heat and you will never see the damage.
Pull the right end	On a clinch and a Palomar, seat the knot by pulling the <i>standing line</i> steadily — not by yanking the tag.
Leave a short tag	About 1/8 inch. Cutting flush lets the tag pull back through under load; leaving half an inch collects weed.
Look at it	Coils should lie in a neat barrel with no crossovers. If it looks wrong it is wrong. Cut it off and tie it again — it takes twenty seconds.
Retie often	After every fish over a couple of pounds, after any snag, and after fishing rock. Run the last two feet of line between your fingers: if you feel roughness, cut it back and retie.
Braid is different	Braid is slippery. Use a Palomar, or add extra wraps to a uni. A standard clinch in braid will slip.

Two things that are not knots

Snap swivel	A fast way to change lures, and it lets a lure swing freely. But it is one more failure point and it is visible — so on Pine Lake’s clear water, tie direct.
Wire leader	Not optional for pike, <i>see the Northern Pike sheet</i> . Most are pre-made with a swivel and snap. If you tie your own, use a haywire twist rather than trying to knot single-strand wire.

Teaching these
Practise on rope or paracord first, at a size a child can see, before touching 6 lb monofilament on a windy dock. Learn the improved clinch until it can be tied without looking, then the Palomar. Those two alone will cover everything on every rig sheet in this guide.

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Handling & Release

Do this right and it costs you thirty seconds

A released fish that dies anyway was not released

Most fish you catch on these lakes go back — everything under 14 inches, every bass out of season, and anything you simply do not need. Whether those fish survive is decided almost entirely in the sixty seconds after they reach the boat, and almost all of it is under your control.

The rules, in order of how much they matter

- 1. Keep it in the water** Every second out of water is a second not breathing. Unhook a fish in the net, in the water, whenever you can. If you want a photograph, get the camera ready *first*, then lift.
- 2. Wet your hands** Dry hands, a dry towel and a dry deck strip the protective slime coat, and the raw patch underneath is where infection and fungus start. Wet hands, wet net, wet everything.
- 3. Support the weight** One hand under the belly on anything over a couple of pounds. Holding a heavy fish vertically by the jaw stretches and tears the joint and the organs behind it. A bass under about two pounds is fine held by the lower lip; above that, use two hands.
- 4. Never touch the gills** Gill filaments are exposed blood vessels. A fish bleeding from the gills is a fish that will die, whatever it looks like when it swims off. No fingers under the plate, ever.
- 5. Cut the line on a deep hook** If the hook is in the throat or gut, **do not dig for it**. Cut the line as close as you can and let the fish go. A left hook rusts out or is expelled; a torn oesophagus does not heal.
- 6. Revive it properly** Hold it upright, facing into any current, or move it gently *forward* through the water. Never sweep it back and forth — water runs the wrong way through the gills and it does harm rather than good. Let go when it kicks free on its own.

What makes it worse

Factor	What to do about it
Warm water	Above roughly 75 °F a fish recovers slowly and its oxygen demand is high. In July and August, keep handling times short, revive longer, and consider moving to a different lesson for the day if fish are clearly struggling. Pike are the most fragile of the lot in warm water.
Deep water	A fish pulled quickly from more than about 25–30 ft may suffer barotrauma: the swim bladder over-expands and it cannot swim down. Signs are bloating, bulging eyes, or a fish that floats on its side. If you are catching fish deep and intend to release them, fish shallower or keep what you catch.
Long fight	Playing a fish to complete exhaustion on light line is hard on it. Use tackle heavy enough to land the fish quickly.
Treble hooks	Three times the chance of a bad hookset. Crush the barbs, or replace a set of trebles with single hooks on baits you use around fish you will release.
Handling a pike	Backward-facing teeth and a fish strong enough to thrash. Jaw spreaders and long pliers, every time. <i>see the Northern Pike sheet</i>

Keep a fish properly, too

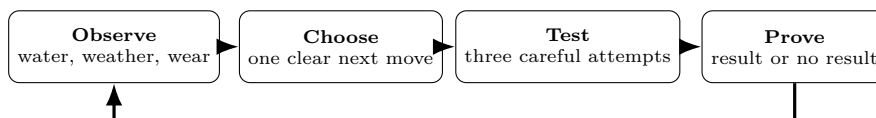
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|---------------------------------|--|
| Decide early | Kill it or release it in the first minute. A fish kept on a stringer for two hours and then released is worse off than one killed immediately, and it is worse eating than one iced immediately. |
| Ice it | A cooler with ice, not a bucket of lake water. Quality falls fast in a warm bucket, and this is the single biggest difference between panfish that taste good and panfish that do not. |
| Take a meal, not a limit | Especially on bluegill beds in June, where the big males you are catching are the ones guarding the nests. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i> |
| Know the rules | Length and bag limits are per water body and change every year. Measure before you decide. <i>see the Seasonal Calendar sheet</i> |

Clean, drain, dry. Before you leave a landing: remove all weed and mud, drain the livewell, bilge and bait bucket, and never move live fish or lake water to another water body. Wisconsin enforces this. Invasive species and fish disease move on trailers, and once they are in a lake like Pine they do not come back out.

Teaching it

This is the sheet to work through before the first trip, not after the first fish. A child who is taught to wet their hands and keep the fish in the net will do it for the rest of their life without thinking about it; one who learns it after dropping a bass on a hot dock has already learnt the other thing.

Use a closed-loop check



Question	Check	Recovery
What changed?	Name one visible or measurable fact: wind direction, depth, water temperature, abrasion, knot shape, lure track, fish reflex, or elapsed time.	If you cannot name the change, observe for one minute before changing equipment.
What am I testing?	Change one variable only and state what success will look like before the attempt.	Restore the last known setup; avoid changing lure, depth, speed, and location together.
Is the system sound?	Trace the full chain from hand to fish: line, knot, leader, hook, drag, handling tool, route home.	Stop on any rough line, crossed wrap, open snap, dull point, missing tool, or unsafe condition; repair or leave.
What proves completion?	A repeatable result and a final tactile/visual check, not merely finishing the written steps.	Repeat slowly under good light. If the check is ambiguous, treat it as a failure.

Final proof before the next cast

Say the plan in one sentence. Tug-test the terminal connection, touch-check the last two feet of line, confirm hook point and snap closure, set the drag, and identify the safe landing and release route. If weather, visibility, footing, or fish condition makes that route doubtful, change the plan before casting.

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A First Trip

Plan for catching, not for fishing

How to take somebody fishing who has never been

The failure mode of a first trip is always the same: an adult who wants to catch a good fish takes a beginner to a place where good fish live, and the beginner spends four hours not catching anything and concludes that fishing is boring. They are right. Plan the opposite trip.



HOOKLESS PRACTICE ON GRASS



SHORT FIXED-FLOAT SESSION



WET SUPPORT AT WATER LEVEL

The plan

Target bluegill	Not bass, not walleye, not "whatever bites". In June a bluegill bed will produce a fish every few minutes, and constant action is the entire point. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Go in June	Late May through June, when panfish are on the beds in 1–4 ft of water and you can see them. Pine Lake spot 6 ; North Lake spot 1 .
Go in the evening	Two hours before dark, not eight in the morning. Warmer, calmer, better bite, and a natural end to the trip.
Keep it short	Ninety minutes. Leave while it is still fun. The trip should end because you decided to end it, not because somebody has stopped enjoying it.
One rod each	A short spinning rod, 4lb line, a fixed bobber a couple of feet above a size 8 hook, half a worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i> — but use a fixed float, not a slip float, for the first trip.
Pinch the barbs	Flatten every barb with pliers. You will lose a few fish and you will save yourself the one memory that ends the hobby: a barbed hook in a finger, an hour from the car.

What to bring

- | | |
|--|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Rod, already rigged, at home• A spare rod, also already rigged• Worms, more than you think• Long-nose pliers• Nail clippers for line• Landing net• Wet towel | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Life jackets that fit <i>them</i>• Sunscreen and a hat• Bug spray• Snacks and water — more than the fishing gear, honestly• Something to keep fish in, if keeping• A first-aid kit with tweezers |
|--|---|

The first hour, in order

1. Rig both rods at home.

2. Pinch each barb flat with pliers.
3. Pull each knot hard.
4. Cover each hook for transport.
5. Put the fitted life jacket on the beginner.
6. Put your own life jacket on.
7. Clip a hookless casting plug to one rod.
8. Stand on grass with everyone behind the caster.
9. Demonstrate one short underhand flip.
10. Let the beginner make five flips.
11. Stop practice when the plug lands forward without crossing anyone.
12. Replace the plug with the covered fishing rig.
13. Uncover the hook only at the fishing position.
14. Set the float so the bait rides just above the visible bed.
15. Let the beginner bait, cast, watch, and reel.
16. Hand over the spare rod immediately when the first rod tangles.
17. Net the first fish at water level.
18. Wet both sets of hands.
19. Support the fish horizontally.
20. Identify one visible feature.
21. Release the fish before preparing the next cast.
22. Leave at 90 minutes or while the beginner still wants one more cast, whichever comes first.

Checks and stop branches

Practice passes only when every cast travels forward and the hookless plug stays clear of people. Fishing passes only when the life jacket remains fitted, the hook is controlled, and the adult can reach the beginner. If thunder, strong wind, unsafe footing, cold stress, panic, or repeated hook-control loss appears, stop and leave. If no fish contacts the bait in 15 minutes, shorten the depth once; after another 15 minutes, move once or switch to looking for aquatic life rather than extending the trip.

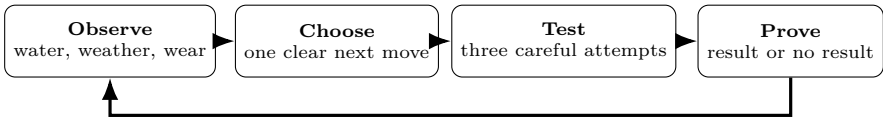
Things that go wrong, and the fix

Problem	Fix
Tangles	Inevitable. Carry the pre-rigged spare rod, hand it over, and untangle the first one later. Do not make a child stand and watch you pick at a bird's nest for ten minutes.
Nothing biting	You are in the wrong spot or too deep. Move shallower, go smaller, use less bait. Half a worm out-fishes a whole one for panfish every time.
Bored	The bite has slowed. Change activity rather than persisting: look at what is in the water, catch a crayfish under a rock, throw the cast net, go home. Fishing is not the only good thing about being at a lake.
Hook in a finger	This is why the barbs are pinched. Back it out the way it went in, clean it, plaster on it, carry on. With a barb still on, cut the line and see a doctor.
Frightened of the fish	Normal. Hold it yourself first, let them touch it while you hold it, and do not push. They will pick one up within a couple of trips.

The measure of success

Not the size of the fish, and not how many. The measure is whether they ask to go again. Everything on this sheet is arranged to make that answer yes.

Use a closed-loop check



Question	Check	Recovery
What changed?	Name one visible or measurable fact: wind direction, depth, water temperature, abrasion, knot shape, lure track, fish reflex, or elapsed time.	If you cannot name the change, observe for one minute before changing equipment.
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First-trip worksheet

Before leaving home

Proof	Recorded result / correction
Live rule and weather checked	
Return time told to another adult	
Life jackets fitted and buckled	
Two rods rigged; barbs flattened	
Hookless plug and hook covers packed	
Food, water, sun, insects, first aid	

Trip checkpoints

Time	Observable check	Pass, correction, or stop
Arrival	Wind, footing, jackets, hook control	
After practice	Five forward hookless flips	
15 minutes	Contact, depth, attention	
30 minutes	Contact after one change	
First fish	Net, wet hands, support, release	
Departure	Head count, hooks covered, site clean	

Proof after the trip

Beginner did independently:

Frustration appeared when:

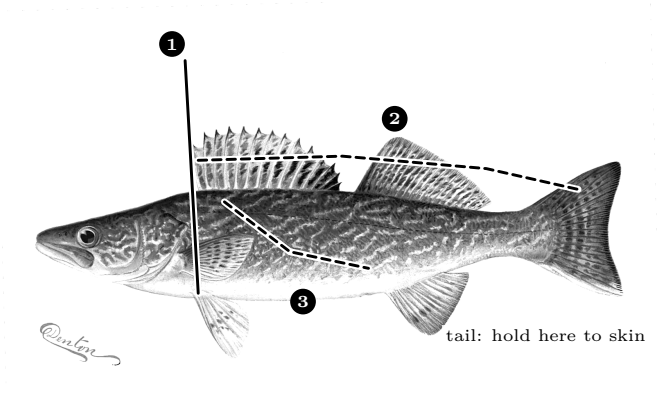
The adult changed:

Evidence the session ended in time:

One change before the next trip:

V Cooking

How good each fish is to eat, how to fillet it — with the cuts drawn on the same plate you identified it from — which bones to watch for, and three ways to cook it.



The Pike Perch or Wall-Eyed Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The reason people drive to Wisconsin. Firm, white, large-flaked, and so mild that the fish tastes of what you cook it in.
Texture	Dense and moist, holds together in a pan where a bluegill falls apart. Forgiving of slight overcooking.
Oil	Low. Keeps poorly frozen past about four months — the flavour goes flat rather than fishy.
Best size	18–22 in, which is also the legal window here. A very large walleye is coarser and worth releasing anyway.
Yield	About 35% of whole weight as skinless fillet. A 20 in fish gives two fillets around 6 oz each — one generous portion.
Skin	Always remove it. Walleye skin is tough and does not crisp.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate**, angling slightly toward the head, until you feel the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone from head to tail, letting the spine guide the knife. One long stroke beats twenty short ones. Leave the fillet attached at the tail as a handle.
3. **Lift the fillet and slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little meat as you can. Or skip this and pull the rib bones with pliers after skinning.
4. **Skin it:** lay the fillet skin-side down, hold the tail, and run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle, sawing gently while pulling the skin.
5. **Take the cheeks.** Two coin-sized nuggets of the best meat on the fish, in the hollow behind and below the eye. Cut a semicircle through the skin, pop the meat out with the knife tip, peel the skin off. Most people throw these away. Do not be most people.
6. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it on ice or in the pan.

Bones

Rib cage	The only bones to deal with, and step 3 removes them.
No Y-bones	Unlike pike, a walleye fillet is genuinely boneless once the ribs are out. <i>see the Cooking Northern Pike sheet</i>
Run a finger	Along the fillet before cooking, tip to tail, feeling for anything sharp. Thirty seconds now saves a bad mouthful later.

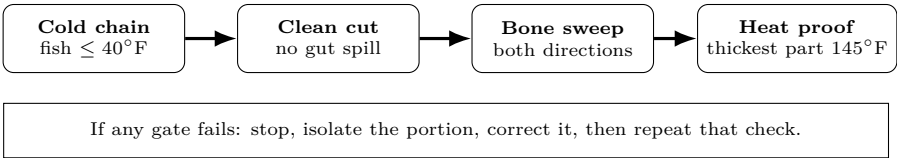
Three ways to cook it

Method	How
Pan-fried	The standard, and the best. Dry the fillet hard. Dredge in seasoned flour, or beaten egg then cracker crumbs. Medium-high heat, butter and a little oil so the butter does not burn. Three minutes a side for a half-inch fillet. Lemon. Nothing else.
Beer-battered	For a fish fry. Flour, cornstarch, baking powder, cold beer, whisked to thin-cream consistency. 375 °F oil, three to four minutes to golden. Drain on a rack, never on paper — paper steams the crust off.
Baked whole fillets	For a bigger batch. 400 °F, butter, lemon slices, paprika, ten to twelve minutes. Done when it flakes at a gentle push and the flesh has just turned opaque.

The one rule

Walleye is a mild fish and every minute past done makes it worse. Pull it when the centre has *just* gone from glassy to opaque — it carries on cooking off the heat. Overcooked walleye is dry and ordinary, which is a waste of the best fish in the lake.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

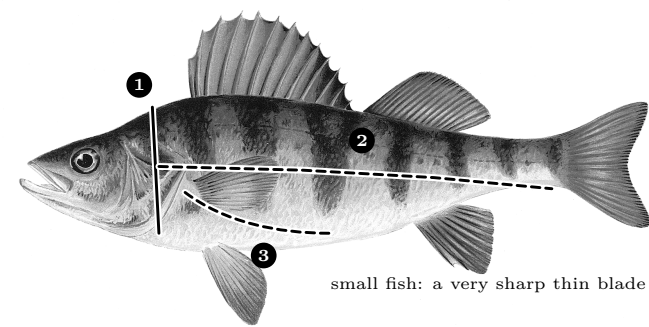
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For walleye, pike, bass and catfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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Cooking Yellow Perch

Pound for pound the finest eating in fresh water

Perca flavescens — in the kitchen



Yellow or Barred Perch — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The best-eating fish in either lake, and arguably in fresh water. Sweeter and firmer than walleye, in a smaller package.
Texture	Firm, fine-grained, faintly sweet. Never mushy.
Best size	9 in and up makes filleting worth the effort. Below that, pan-dress instead.
Yield	Low — about 25%, and a 9 in perch gives two fillets of barely 1.5 oz. This is a fish you need a dozen of.
Ice fishing	Winter perch out of 34 °F water are the best of all. see the <i>Seasonal Calendar sheet</i>
Scales	Fine and very well attached. Filleting and skinning beats scaling every time.

Filleting a small fish

1. Use a **thin, very sharp, flexible blade**. A thick knife on a 9 in perch wastes half the fish.
2. **Cut behind the gill plate** down to the backbone.
3. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail in one stroke. On a fish this small, resist sawing.
4. **Skin it** from the tail, and take the ribs with the skin if you can — on perch it is often faster to cut the rib section away entirely and accept the small loss.
5. **Or pan-dress instead:** scale, gut, cut the head off behind the gills, and cook it whole on the bone. Below about 9 in this gives you more food than filleting does.

Bones and what to watch for

Spiny dorsal	The first dorsal fin is genuinely sharp and so are the gill covers. Handle a live perch from the head-on direction, or with a cloth.
Rib cage	Small and fine. Cut it out or pull it with pliers.
Nothing else	No Y-bones, no pin bones. A perch fillet is clean.
Pan-dressed	Eaten off the bone, the frame lifts out in one piece after cooking.

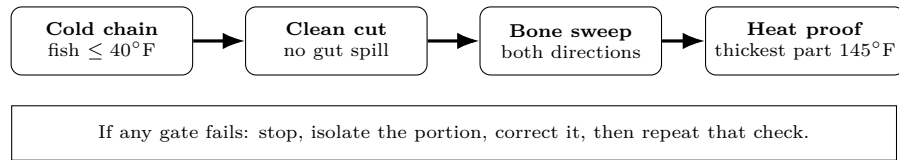
Cooking it

Method	How
Pan-fried	The only method that really matters. Egg wash, then cracker crumbs or fine cornmeal. Butter, medium-high, ninety seconds a side. They are small — they cook fast.
Perch fry	The Friday institution. Beer batter, 375 °F, two to three minutes. Serve with rye bread, coleslaw and a lemon wedge, which is how it is done here.
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed fish, scored, dusted in seasoned flour, shallow-fried until the fins go crisp. Eat the fins. They are the best part and nobody believes it until they try.

Worth the work
Perch are small and cleaning a dozen takes a while, which is exactly why so few people bother and why the ones who do eat better than everybody else. Set up an assembly line: one person fillets, one skins, one rinses and ices. Twenty

minutes for a family meal of the best fish in the county.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

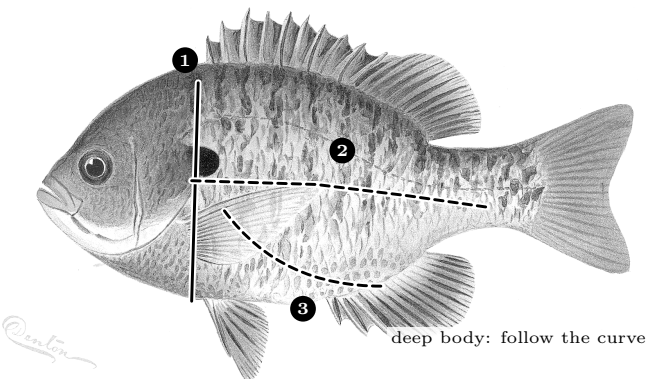
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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Cooking Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus — in the kitchen

The fish most people learn to clean on



Blue Gill Sun Fish — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Sweet, delicate and white. Slightly softer than perch but every bit as good, and there are usually a lot more of them.
Texture	Fine and tender. It will fall apart if you handle it roughly in the pan — that is the only difficulty.
Best size	8 in and up to fillet. Below that, pan-dress. A 9 in bluegill is a trophy and a superb meal.
Yield	Poor — about 22%. The deep body shape means a lot of fish becomes a little fillet. Budget three or four fish per person.
Ethics	June bed fish are the easiest to catch and the ones the population needs. Take a meal, not a cooler. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Freezing	Freeze in a block of water rather than dry — delicate flesh burns quickly in a freezer.

Filleting a deep-bodied fish

1. **Cut behind the gill plate**, following the curve of the gill cover down and around, to the backbone.
2. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail. On a deep-bodied fish the backbone sits high — roughly halfway up — so aim higher than feels right.
3. **Take the ribs** with a shallow arc, or cut the whole belly section away.
4. **Skin it** from the tail end. Bluegill skin releases easily.
5. **Or pan-dress:** scale it with the back of a knife against the grain, gut it, cut the head off behind the gills, trim the fins. Cook whole. For fish under about 8 in this is both faster and gives more food.

Bones and what to watch for

Spines	The dorsal spines are sharp. Trim the whole spiny dorsal off first with kitchen shears — it makes the rest safer and quicker.
Rib cage	Fine and easy to lift out.
No pin bones	A bluegill fillet is clean once the ribs are out.
Pan-dressed	The whole skeleton lifts out in one piece after cooking. Teach a child to do this and they will eat fish for life.

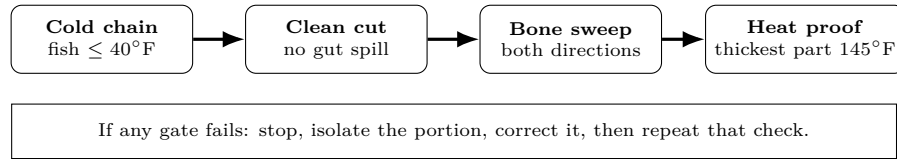
Cooking it

Method	How
Cornmeal-fried	Buttermilk, then fine cornmeal with salt and cayenne. Hot oil, two minutes a side. The classic and still the best.
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed, scored twice on each side, floured, shallow-fried until crisp. Eat everything except the spine.
Bluegill cakes	For a big catch of small fish. Poach the fillets, flake, bind with egg, breadcrumbs, spring onion and mustard. Fry as patties. This is what to do with a hundred small ones.

The teaching fish

Bluegill is the right fish to learn knife work on: there are lots of them, they are cheap to ruin, and the anatomy is simple and obvious. Let a teenager fillet six badly before you correct anything. The seventh will be fine, and they will have learnt more than any amount of watching.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
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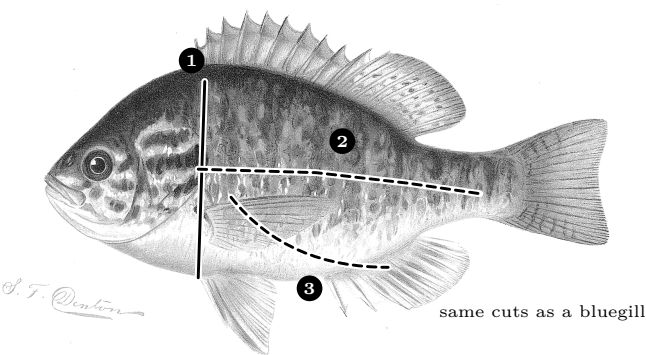
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Cooking Pumpkinseed

Lepomis gibbosus — in the kitchen

Treat it exactly as a bluegill, because it is one for these purposes



Sunfish (*Eupomotis gibbosus*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Indistinguishable from bluegill on the plate — sweet, white, delicate.
Size	Usually smaller than the bluegill it shares a bed with, which is the only practical difference. A 7 in pumpkinseed is a good one.
Yield	About 20%. Below 7 in, pan-dress rather than fillet.
Mixed catch	You will almost always be cleaning these alongside bluegill. There is no reason to separate them.
Hybrids	Bluegill and pumpkinseed interbreed freely. If a fish fits neither description, it eats the same either way.
Freezing	In water, not dry. Delicate flesh burns fast.

Filleting or pan-dressing

1. **Shear off the spiny dorsal** with kitchen scissors before anything else. It makes the fish safe to hold.
2. **Cut behind the gill plate**, following the gill cover’s curve, down to the backbone.
3. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail. The backbone sits high in a deep-bodied fish — aim higher than instinct suggests.
4. **Lift the ribs out** with a shallow arc.
5. **Skin from the tail.**
6. **Under 7 in, pan-dress instead:** scale against the grain with a knife back, gut, head off behind the gills, fins trimmed. Cook whole on the bone. More food and less work.

Bones and what to watch for

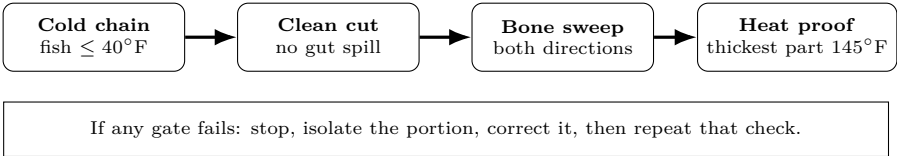
Spines	Sharp dorsal and anal spines. Shear them first.
Rib cage	Fine, easily removed.
No pin bones	Clean fillet.
Whole fish	The skeleton lifts out in one piece after cooking, which is the trick to show a child.

Cooking it

Method	How
Cornmeal-fried	Buttermilk, fine cornmeal, hot oil, two minutes a side. Exactly as bluegill. <i>see the Cooking Bluegill sheet</i>
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed, scored, floured, shallow-fried until the fins crisp.
Mixed panfish fry	The normal outcome of a June evening: bluegill, pumpkinseed and a few crappie in one pan. No need to sort them.

Worth one lesson
Before you clean a June catch, sort the pile into bluegill and pumpkinseed by the ear flap — solid black versus an orange-red spot — and count each. It takes two minutes, it teaches an identification that sticks, and it tells you something real about which fish that bay is producing. <i>see the Pumpkinseed sheet</i>

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

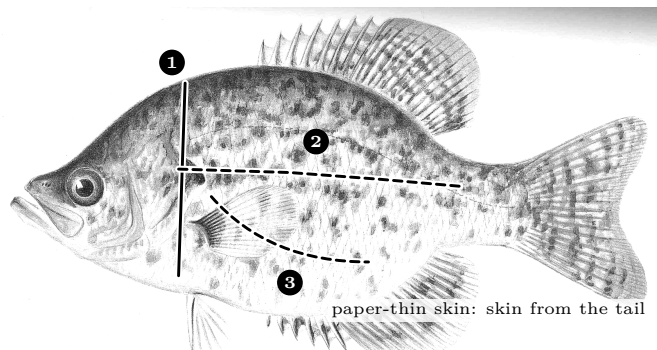
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Cooking Black Crappie

Pomoxis nigromaculatus — in the kitchen

The mildest fillet in the lake



Calico Bass; Strawberry Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	The mildest and whitest of the panfish, with a slightly larger flake than bluegill. Many people rate it above every other panfish.
Texture	Soft, delicate, large-flaked for its size. Wants a gentle hand.
Best size	10 in and up. Crappie are thin fish, so a 10 in crappie yields less than a 10 in bass.
Yield	About 24%. Two fillets of roughly 2 oz from a 10 in fish.
Skin	Thin and tears easily. Skin from the tail with a firm grip.
Winter fish	Crappie taken through the ice are the best of the year — cold water firms the flesh noticeably.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

The mouth	The membrane is famously thin, which is a fishing problem rather than a cleaning one — but it also means the head end tears easily under the knife. Cut, do not pull.
Rib cage	Fine and easily lifted.
No pin bones	Clean fillet once the ribs are out.
Handle gently	Crappie flesh is the softest here. Do not stack fillets under weight.

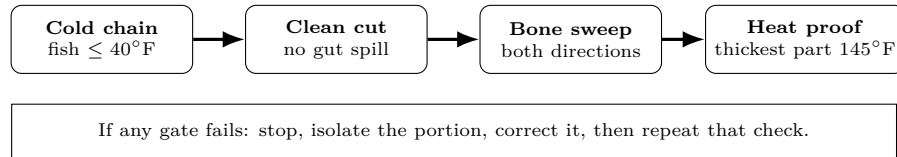
Cooking it

Method	How
Lightly fried	Seasoned flour only — a heavy batter buries a fish this mild. Butter, medium heat, two minutes a side.
Broiled with butter	Fillets on a buttered tray, paprika, lemon, six to eight minutes under a hot broiler. Nothing else needed.
Fish chowder	Crappie's softness is an asset in a chowder. Potato, onion, bacon, cream, and the fillets added in the last four minutes so they flake through.

Do not batter it heavily

Crappie is the mildest thing you will catch in these lakes, and the standard beer batter that suits walleye completely overwhelms it. Flour, butter and lemon. If you cannot taste the fish, the recipe is wrong for it.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

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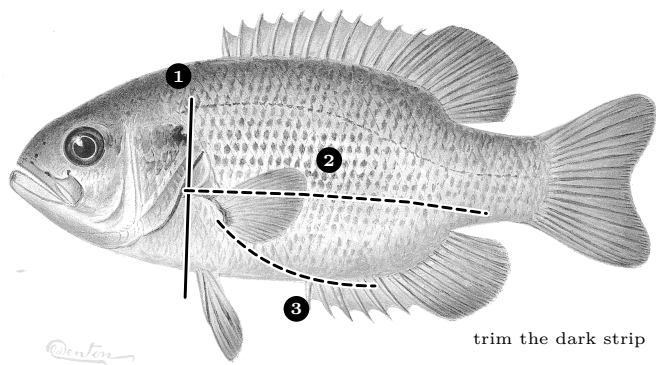
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Cooking Rock Bass

Ambloplites rupestris — in the kitchen

Under-rated, abundant, and best eaten the day you catch it



Rock Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Good — white, mild and perfectly pleasant, if a little softer than perch or bluegill. Badly under-rated because it is so easy to catch. ●●●●●
Texture	Softer and coarser than the other panfish. Best cooked hot and fast.
Freshness matters	This is the one panfish that noticeably deteriorates on a stringer. Ice it immediately and eat it the same day and it is genuinely good; leave it warm for three hours and it is not.
Best size	8 in and up. Pine Lake's gravel produces plenty.
Yield	About 22%. Deep-bodied, like a bluegill.
Counts as	Panfish, in the 25 per day aggregate.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

Spines	Six anal spines — the identification mark — and a sharp spiny dorsal. Shear the dorsal off before you start.
Gill covers	Sharp-edged. Handle from the front.
Rib cage	Fine, lifts out easily.
Dark strip	Trim the lateral dark muscle as you would on a bass. It is where any muddiness sits.

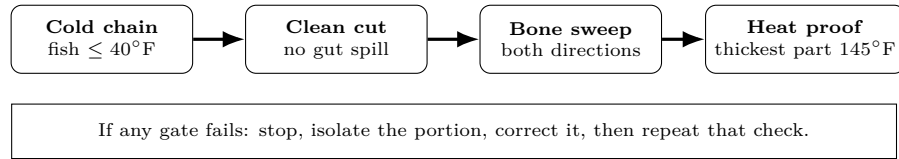
Cooking it

Method	How
Hot and fast	Cornmeal, very hot oil, ninety seconds a side. The softer flesh needs speed — a slow pan turns it to mush.
In a fish boil	Rock bass hold up in a pot better than they do in a pan. Potatoes, onions, salt, then the fish in for the last five minutes.
Cakes	Like bluegill, a good candidate for poaching, flaking and binding into patties when you have caught a lot of them.

The fish that saves the trip

Rock bass are aggressive, abundant, easy for a child to catch, and perfectly good on a plate the same evening. On a slow morning with a bored ten-year-old, a rock bass every three casts is worth more than a walleye you did not catch. *see the **A First Trip** sheet*

Prove the meal before serving



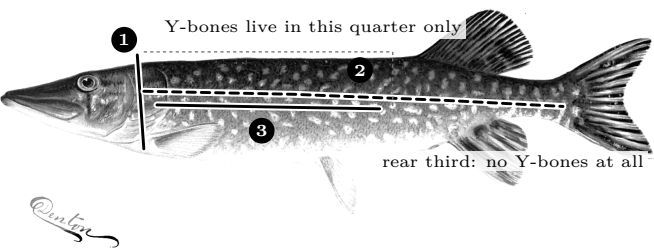
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The Pike — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	White, firm, clean and genuinely excellent — comparable to walleye. The Y-bones are the whole of its bad reputation and they are entirely solvable.
Texture	Firm and large-flaked, close to a cod. Holds together beautifully.
Best size	24–30 in. Big pike are coarser and are the breeders. The 26 in minimum here means you are keeping mid-size fish anyway.
Yield	About 30% by the five-fillet method — you deliberately sacrifice the Y-bone strip.
Slime	Pike are heavily slimed. Rinse in cold water before you start, and rinse the board between fish, or everything becomes slippery and dangerous.
Skin	Thick and strong. Comes off cleanly and is not eaten.

The five-fillet method — how to beat the Y-bones

A pike has an extra row of **Y-shaped intramuscular bones**, sitting above the lateral line in the *front half* of each fillet only. They are floating bones — they connect to nothing — so you cannot pull them like pin bones. You cut around them instead, and you deliberately give up a strip of meat. That is the whole trick, and it takes about two minutes once you have done it three times.

1. **Take two fillets normally.** Cut behind the gill plate to the backbone, turn the blade, run to the tail. Remove the ribs.
2. **Lay a fillet skin-side down.** Feel for the row of bone tips with a fingertip, running along the fillet slightly above the lateral line, from the head end back to roughly where the dorsal fin was — about the front 60% of the fillet. Behind that point there are none.
3. **Cut along the top of the Y-bones.** Starting at the head end, slice horizontally just *above* the bone tips, keeping the blade flat against them, until the cut runs out where the bones stop. This frees the whole upper-front section: **fillet one**, boneless.
4. **Cut along the bottom of the Y-bones.** Same again, this time just *below* the row, blade riding along the underside of the bones. This frees the lower-front section: **fillet two**, boneless.
5. **What is left** is a narrow strip containing every Y-bone, plus the rear third of the fillet which never had any. Cut the clean rear section off and keep it — **fillet three**.
6. Repeat on the other side. Five boneless pieces from one fish, and one bony strip that goes in the stockpot or the bin.

Bones and what to watch for

Y-bones	Above the lateral line, front 60% of the fillet only, floating and un-pullable. Cut above and below them, as in steps 3 and 4.
Do not try pliers	They break rather than pull, and you end up with bone fragments in the meat. This is the mistake everyone makes once.
The alternative	On smaller pike, score the fillet crossways every 3 mm down to the skin and deep-fry hot. The bones are fine enough to dissolve and become unnoticeable. It works, but the five-fillet method is better.
Pickling	Traditional and effective — the brine softens the Y-bones completely. Use a recipe with a boiling-water step, because the broad fish tapeworm is the one parasite in Wisconsin fish that matters to people.

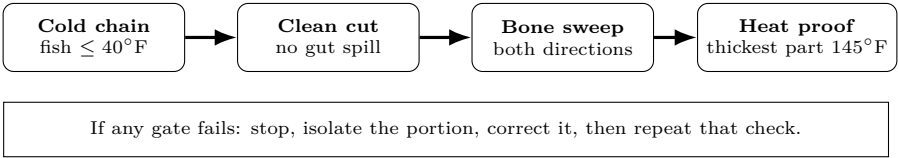
Cooking it

Method	How
Beer-battered	Pike is firm enough to take a proper batter. 375 °F, three to four minutes. Many people who say they dislike pike have only ever eaten it badly cleaned.
Poached	The firm flake suits gentle cooking. Court-bouillon or milk with bay and peppercorns, eight minutes at a bare simmer. Cold with mayonnaise the next day is better still.
Pickled	Cube the flesh, brine in salt for 48 hours, rinse, then cover in a boiled and cooled vinegar-sugar-pickling-spice solution with sliced onion. Two weeks in the fridge. The classic Wisconsin treatment and it makes the Y-bone problem vanish entirely.

Do this once with somebody watching

The five-fillet method is very hard to learn from words and very easy to learn from one demonstration. Do the first pike slowly, with a finger on the bone row the whole time so you can feel where the blade is. After two fish it becomes automatic, and pike goes from a fish people throw back to one of the best on the lake. *see the **Northern Pike sheet***

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

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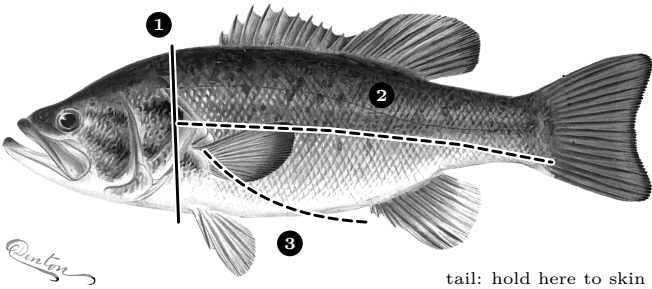
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Cooking Largemouth Bass

Better than its reputation, if you take it from cold water

Micropterus salmoides — in the kitchen



The Large-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Much better than anglers say, provided the water was cold. A bass from 50 °F water in April is clean and sweet; the same fish in August can taste of weed and mud.
Texture	Firm and meaty, larger flake than walleye, holds up to grilling and to a heavier sauce.
The mud line	Flavour lives in the dark red lateral strip of muscle just under the skin. Trim it off and most of the complaint goes with it.
Best size	14–17 in. A big old bass is a breeder and coarse eating — put it back.
Yield	About 30% as skinless fillet. A 15 in bass gives two fillets of roughly 4 oz.
Season	Keep bass in spring and autumn; release them in high summer. This is a flavour judgement, not just a conservation one.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

Rib cage	The only real bone structure. Step 3 removes it.
The red strip	Run the knife under the dark lateral muscle and lift it off. On a summer bass this is the difference between a good meal and a bad one.
Scales	If you are cooking skin-on, scale it first — largemouth scales are large, tough and will not soften.
Check by feel	Run a finger tip-to-tail before cooking.

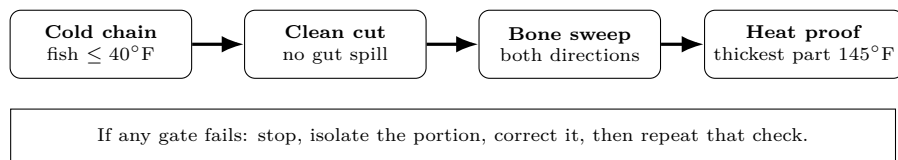
Cooking it

Method	How
Blackened	Bass takes spice better than any other fish here. Coat heavily in paprika, cayenne, thyme, garlic and pepper. Very hot cast iron, butter, two to three minutes a side until the crust is dark. Cook it outside — it smokes.
Grilled in foil	Fillet, butter, lemon, onion, sealed in a foil packet. Twelve minutes over medium coals. Forgiving, and it keeps a firmer fish moist.
Fish tacos	Cube the fillet, dust with cumin and chilli, sear hard and fast. Warm tortillas, cabbage, lime, something creamy. Bass holds its shape in a taco where a bluegill would disintegrate.

Why bass has a bad name

Almost every complaint about eating bass comes from one of three things: a fish taken from warm summer water, the dark lateral strip left on, or a fish carried around on a stringer for hours before cleaning. Fix all three — cold water, trim the strip, ice it immediately — and it is a genuinely good fish. *see the **Handling & Release** sheet*

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

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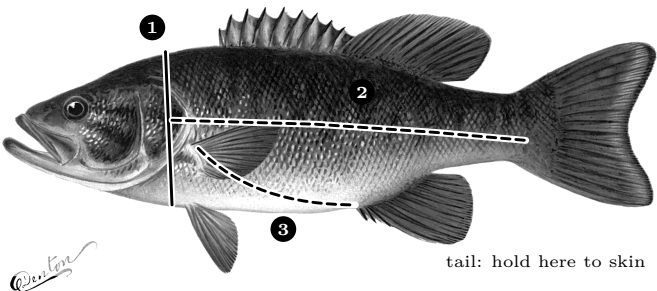
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Cooking Smallmouth Bass

Micropterus dolomieu — in the kitchen

Cleaner-tasting than its cousin, because of where it lives



The Small-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Better eating than largemouth and noticeably cleaner, because smallmouth live over gravel and rock rather than in soft-bottomed weed. ●●●●●
Texture	Firm, white, tight-flaked. The best bass in either lake for the pan.
Flavour	Mild with a faint sweetness. A crayfish diet shows in the eating.
Best size	14–17 in. Pine Lake's gravel bottom produces good ones.
Yield	About 32% as skinless fillet.
Worth saying	Smallmouth are the best sporting fish in these lakes and there are not many big ones. Take a meal, release the rest.

Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

Bones and what to watch for

Rib cage	Removed at step 3. Nothing else to deal with.
Red strip	Less pronounced than on largemouth, but still worth trimming.
Skin	Comes away cleanly and is not worth eating.
Check by feel	Run a finger tip-to-tail before cooking.

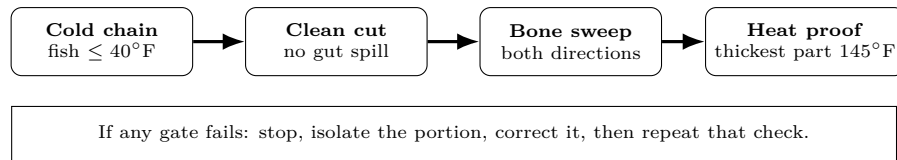
Cooking it

Method	How
Pan-fried	Flour, salt, pepper, butter. Three minutes a side. Smallmouth is clean enough that heavy seasoning is a waste of it.
En papillote	Fillet on parchment with lemon, dill, a knob of butter and a splash of white wine. Fold and seal, 400 °F, twelve minutes. Opens at the table.
Over a fire	A whole gutted smallmouth, scored, stuffed with lemon and herbs, wrapped in foil and buried in coals for twenty minutes. The best thing you can do with one on the shore of the lake it came from.

Bottom matters

A fish tastes of where it lives. Smallmouth from Pine Lake's clean gravel are consistently better than largemouth from the same lake's soft weedy bays — same water, different bottom, different flavour. If you want to know how a lake will eat before you cook it, look at what is under the fish. *see the **Reading Water** sheet*

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
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Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

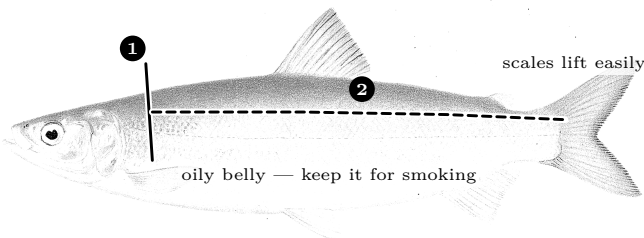
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For walleye, pike, bass and catfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR's Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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Cooking Cisco

Coregonus artedii — in the kitchen

An oily, fine-fleshed fish that wants to be smoked



Cisco from Hemlock Lake — plate from the Freshwater and Marine Image Bank, University of Washington. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Excellent, but nothing like the others — rich, oily and fine-textured, closer to a small trout or a herring than to walleye. ●●●●○
Oil	High, and unusually so for these lakes. That is exactly why it smokes so well and why it does not keep long fresh.
Handling	The most perishable fish in the guide. Bleed it and ice it within minutes or the oil turns. This is not fussiness — a cisco left warm for two hours is not worth cooking.
Best size	10–14 in.
Yield	About 40%, the best in the guide — a straightforward, thick-bodied fish with a small head.
Season	Late autumn and through the ice, when they are at their fattest. <i>see the Cisco sheet</i>

Cleaning it

1. **Bleed it at the boat** — a cut through the gill arches — and put it straight on ice. This matters more for cisco than for anything else here.
2. **Scale it** if you are smoking or grilling skin-on. Cisco scales are large and lift with almost no effort.
3. **Gut it**, and for smoking leave the head on — it gives you something to hang it by.
4. **Or fillet normally:** behind the gill to the backbone, along the spine to the tail, ribs out. The flesh is soft, so use a sharp blade and few strokes.
5. **Leave the belly meat on.** It is the fattiest and best part, and it is what makes smoked cisco worth doing.

Bones and what to watch for

Pin bones	A row of fine pin bones runs down the fillet. Pull them with needle-nose pliers, in the direction they lean, before cooking.
Rib cage	Fine and soft.
Smoked whole	The frame lifts out in one piece after smoking — another reason to smoke rather than fillet.
Soft flesh	Handle gently and do not stack.

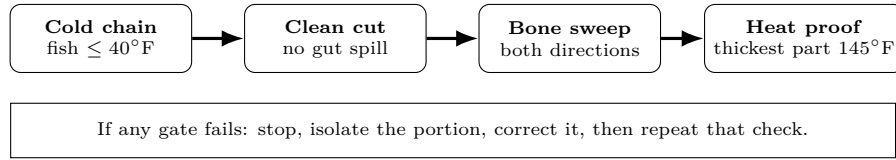
Cooking it

Method	How
Smoked	The right answer. Brine six hours in salt, brown sugar and water. Air-dry until tacky — that skin, the pellicle, is what smoke sticks to. Cold-smoke over apple or alder at 180 °F for three to four hours. Outstanding, and it keeps.
Grilled whole	Scaled, gutted, scored, oiled and salted. Hot grill, four minutes a side. The oil bastes it from inside.
Pan-fried	Fillets, skin on, skin-side down in a hot dry pan — there is enough fat in the fish that it needs almost no oil. Two minutes, flip, one minute.

The one fish here that rewards a smoker

Every other fish in this guide is lean, and lean fish smoke poorly — they go dry and stringy. Cisco is the exception, and a lake that holds them is unusual in this part of Wisconsin. If you have ever wanted a reason to build a smoker, a November cisco from Pine Lake is it. *see the **Cisco** sheet*

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

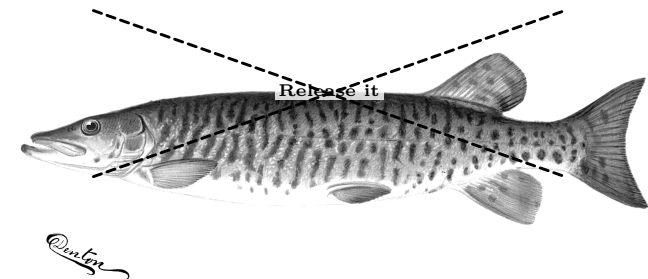
Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For all other species not listed as panfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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Cooking Muskellunge

Esox masquinongy — in the kitchen

Do not eat it — and here is the reason, in numbers



The Mascalonge — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Not a fish to eat, and this is the one sheet in the guide that says so. •••••
Mercury	Muskellunge sit at the top of the food chain and live for fifteen to twenty years, so they accumulate more mercury than anything else in the lake. Wisconsin's statewide guidance is do not eat for women under 50 and children under 15, and one serving per <i>month</i> for everybody else. No other species in this guide carries a do-not-eat line.
Scarcity	Musky are not among the species the DNR lists as common in either lake. A musky here is a rare, old, slow-growing fish.
Regulation	40 in minimum, one per day, open water only. A legal musky is a very large animal.
If you must	The flesh is white and firm, comparable to pike and with the same Y-bone structure. <i>see the Cooking Northern Pike sheet</i>
Better outcome	Photograph it in the net, measure it, and let it go.

If you catch one

1. **Confirm it is a musky and not a pike** before you do anything else. Dark marks on a light body, the lower half of both cheek and gill cover scaleless, six to nine pores per side of the lower jaw. *see the **Muskellunge** sheet*
2. **Measure it in the net, in the water.** Under 40 in it goes back regardless.
3. **Keep it horizontal and wet.** A large musky is injured by its own weight in air. Support the belly.
4. **Unhook it in the water** with long pliers and jaw spreaders. Cut the hook if it is awkward.
5. **Revive it properly** — upright, moving forward, until it swims off under its own power. A big musky may need several minutes.
6. **Photograph it low over the water**, so that if it kicks free it lands in the lake and not on the deck.

Bones and what to watch for

Same as pike	Y-bones above the lateral line in the front of each fillet, floating and un-pullable.
But	The bone structure is not the reason to leave it. The mercury load and the rarity of the fish are.
Handling	Teeth as bad as a pike's on a much larger animal. Jaw spreaders and long pliers, always.
Gear	A landing net big enough for the fish, ready before you hook one.

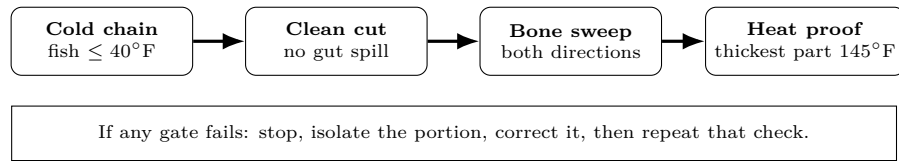
Cooking it

Method	How
—	This sheet does not carry recipes, and that is deliberate. If you want a large white-fleshed fish for the table from these waters, keep a legal northern pike instead: it eats as well, it is far more abundant, it grows faster, and it carries a fraction of the mercury.

Why this sheet exists

It would be easy to leave musky out of a cooking guide entirely. But somebody will eventually catch a legal one and want to know, and the honest answer is a number: Wisconsin's health guidance puts musky in a category by itself, alongside no other inland species. That is worth knowing before the fish is in the cooler rather than after.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
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Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For muskellunge: **do not eat** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per month** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR's Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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VI Field Workbook

Turn the preceding lake, species, rig, reference, and kitchen instruction into a testable trip plan. Record measured conditions, preserve failed predictions, and keep field observations inside the guide's evidence limits.

Field-learning loop

Use the binder as a route through evidence, not as proof that every named fish is present or every mapped spot will produce. Read in this order:

- 1. **Lake sheet:** locate the numbered spot, contour, access context, dated rules, and limits of the map.
- 2. **Species sheet:** identify a catch from diagnostic structure before assigning a name or interpreting abundance.
- 3. **Rig and reference sheets:** choose a controlled presentation and record the variables that can change.
- 4. **Cooking sheet:** use only after lawful retention, positive identification, and a current consumption-advice check.

Questions for Pine Lake

1. Which numbered contour or basin edge best explains the first verified fish contact?

2. Which body structures support the species name, and which likely confusion species were excluded?

3. Does any cisco or muskellunge claim have diagnostic documentation and a current authoritative source, rather than a map label or recollection?

4. Which measured depth, temperature, cover, and presentation combination can be repeated on the next trip?

Before departure · write the prediction

Question	Recorded answer or source
Live rule checked	
Weather / wind / hazards	
Target + evidence basis	
Expected spot / depth / cover	
Starting rig + stop rule	

Measurement log

Record observations before interpreting them. Use instrument readings when available; mark estimates as estimates. One row describes one deliberate change or one verified contact.

Time	Spot / place	Depth ft	Temp / clarity	Cover / bottom	Rig / depth / speed	Result + identification basis

Trip checkpoints

When	Verify, then decide
At launch	Access is lawful; wind, weather, equipment, and return plan remain safe.
After 30 minutes	Record depth and presentation. Change one variable, or move to the next mapped spot; do not rewrite the species evidence.
At first contact	Photograph diagnostic features when safe, measure length, and separate observation from identification.
Before retention	Confirm species, live rule, size, bag, meal advice, cold storage, and intended use.
Before return	Recheck weather, battery or fuel, daylight, and the safest route to access.

Post-trip proof

An outing becomes reusable evidence only when another reader can tell what was observed, how it was identified, and what remains uncertain.

Claim to retain	Proof or correction
Species identification	
Diagnostic photograph / file	
Measured location and conditions	
Presentation that produced contact	
Null result worth preserving	
Rule / advisory source and date	

A FIELD NOTE DOES NOT REPLACE THE EVIDENCE FILTER

A photograph or catch can support identification of that individual. It does not by itself establish abundance, persistence, a fishable population, or the status of another species. Preserve every sheet’s printed qualification until a current authoritative record changes it.

Next-trip decision

Repeat:

Change one variable:

Question still open: